

Nick and Me

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Big brother was mine. I'm not talking about that stupid book we had to read in junior high about how the world was gonna turn weird and everybody could see everything you were doing all the time. No, I'm talking about my real Big Brother. Nick was the guy everybody was scared of. He had a pair on him the size of steel wrecking balls. His face looked like a puzzle with the pieces held together with sticky stuff from a glue gun. He wasn't ugly, just had a few brawls over the years to give him that rough look. It was like he rolled out of bed and forgot to comb his hair. A few scars here and there, chin and over his left eyebrow. When he walked in the bar, or the gym, people took notice, and man, did they move out of the way. I lived with him and Ma after dad took off when I was about eight. We lived downtown in a big brick apartment building on Kirk Street. A fifth-floor walk-up, so it was a real pain in the ass to haul up the groceries and stuff. Luckily, when I went to the store with Nick, he could load up with about six of those shopping bags and take them up in one trip, like he was in one of those "world's strongest man" competitions, where they throw boulders over walls, or pull cars with just their teeth. I held the rest.

One time, when we went into Moxie's, the gym down on the corner, one of those guys in there was doin' preacher curls with a 40-pound bar on the curl bench. He was right in the middle of a set, but as soon as he saw Nick moving towards him, he dropped that sucker right down on the ground and offered it up. Nick just nodded at him, then took over the place. Of course, he had to have a 50-pound bar, but that was just for warm-ups. I'm not too shabby when it comes to

weight lifting, but I aint gonna curl no fifty pounds as a warm-up. Hell, I aint gonna curl a 50-pound weight probably ever. That's okay though, Nick is my brother, like I said. I know he'll stand up for me no matter what.

Milwaukee is where we live. It's where we lived all of our lives. Right there, on Kirk Street in that fifth floor apartment. We used to play kick ball in the alley behind the building and set up bases with dented-in garbage can lids. One time little Mark Conner kicked a ball right through old Mrs. Engel's kitchen. Man, was she pissed. Mark was scared to death, but Nick stepped right up to her and said he was the one who did it. She called my Ma, and Ma had to pay for the window. Somehow Nick gave her cash to pay for it about a week later. I have no idea where a 12-year old came up with sixty bucks, but I was sure proud of him for that. He never told Ma that it was really Mark who did it. None of us did.

The thing about Nick was, he was a real-life Viking - you know? What I mean is we had these ancestors that came from Norway or Sweden or somewhere over there in Viking land and they came over here and stayed in Wisconsin. So, we are Vikings too, I guess. You never hear about Vikings, but they are the biggest bad-asses on the planet. I don't care about gangsters from Mexico or China, or even Irish people. Hell, all they do is drink anyways. What I'm talking about are tall, strong people who survived in the middle of winter all the time. While other people would freeze to death, those bastards kept warm. Not only did they keep warm, but they ran around in short skirts and shit. They made canoes and Viking boats and sailed all over the place. They took over everybody back then. Nobody knows it, but half of Europe is mixed up with Viking blood.

Most of them had red hair I think. We don't really have red hair. But I would say Nick has reddish-brown hair. Ma has brown hair and she was mostly English I guess. When I think of

the way those Vikings used to live over there it makes me all proud. They had those huge swords and when somebody died, they floated them out to sea on a raft and set them on fire. That's the way it should be. None of this taking up space with caskets and shit. Just set me on fire and float me out on a raft. It is so cool to see fire on top of water.

I guess that's why people respect Nick and our family, even though dad took off. He is a modern-day warrior. When we go downtown to the bars, Nick always goes in first to check out the place. The bouncers are even scared of him. He likes to walk into places where everybody is running out. He's a crazy man. He has a girlfriend most of the time, but when they get really clingy he gets rid of them. He just doesn't need that hassle. He goes where he wants, when he wants, and does whatever he wants. Nobody questions that guy.

Nick has a job down at the local metal factory. He runs one of the assembly lines down there. Big metal pieces move past and he separates things. Sometimes he runs one of the big cranes inside that lifts the stuff up to a higher level. He said it's pretty easy for the money. He must make a lot because he has a nice car and a pretty cool apartment down on Werner Street. He lives about five blocks from Ma and me, but he comes over a lot to take care of stuff, so it feels like he still lives here. I wish I made enough money to get my own place, but then again, someone has to be here with Ma. She's getting older and it's hard for her to see. Sometimes she gets up in the middle of the night and runs into furniture. I don't want her to fall down and nobody knows about it. Ma's had a tough life, tougher than any of us. With dad leaving, then putting up with Nick and me, that's something else.

Nick has a cool car, like I said. It's a 1980 Pontiac Trans Am all decked out. It's a V8 with power everything, a T-top, and exhaust splitters. It only had one repaint job, and it's a sweet burnt orange with yellow flames on the side, and the big eagle still on the hood. He got a great

deal from some guy in Chicago who brought it up here. Only cost him 12-grand and has 75,000 miles on her. I love riding in that thing. People always look up when Nick pulls up to the lights in that car.

The other day he comes over to check on us. “What’s Ma doin’ back in the bedroom at this time of day?” he says.

“I don’t know, why?”

“You got to keep an eye on her. She shouldn’t be sleeping in the middle of the day like that. That’s how old people go downhill. They start sleepin’ all day, and pretty soon before you know it, they don’t want to go outside, or eat, or go to the store or nothing” Nick says. Nick was right. I needed to take better care of her. It was my responsibility after all, I was living there to keep an eye on her. I told him I would do a better job and make her get up and sit out in the living room with me. But even when I do that it’s a big drag. All she wants to do is watch game shows and sometimes the cooking channels. Not that she bothers to even cook anymore hardly. It’s like she’s just bored all the time. She never even bothers to call her sister, or go across the hall to talk to Mrs. Canasta. They used to talk and hang out all the time. I don’t know what’s wrong with her.

Ma worked for years being a janitor for the school system. She worked real hard everyday. Those little kids are just pigs. Somebody is always throwing up in the hallway, or spraying urine all over the bathroom. She’s probably cleaned up more kid’s snot and puke than anyone else I know. She started having back problems and had to take retirement. She doesn’t get very much money every month, but also collects some social security. Between her and me with my pizza job money, we make ends meet. It’s not always pretty. There’s a lot of pizza and macaroni around here. But what are you gonna do?

This is the real problem as I see it. I can't afford to go back to school and study to get a "real" job, because somebody has to take care of Ma. Nick says,

"You don't need a degree to get a good job. All you need is to know somebody and you will get a good job someday. That's how it always happens."

Do you think he could get me a job at the metal factory though? No, he never even tries. Even when I complain and beg for him to talk to his boss about me, he won't do it. I don't know what all that's about. But, if Nick doesn't want me down there – there has to be a reason for it.

"What kind of shit do you want to take at school anyway?" Nick says. "All that crap is just a bunch of nerds talking to hear themselves talk. Nobody ever learned anything in college that you can use in the real world. The real world is here – where we live. You're not gonna be a doctor or lawyer or anything like that. Hell, you're too old anyway."

Nick is right. I am too old. I haven't got the brains to go to school. Besides, I have to take care of Ma and just do the best I can with what I got. No one ever died and wished they spent more time in a classroom; all the time they were just wishing they could be done. I do like reading though. I don't tell nobody that. It doesn't matter anyway.

The reason why I'm telling you all this stuff, is because something weird is happening to me. I can't really tell Nick, or Ma, or Bobby down at the pizza joint, because they wouldn't understand. Hell, I don't understand what's happening.

See, this one day I rode my bike to work, and just as I was walking down the sidewalk and into the front door of the pizza place, this girl tripped over the cement while she was walking toward me. She kind of fell into me. She fell and just kind of brushed into me with her shoulder. She had kind of short brown hair and was skinny. Not too skinny, but good looking in a way. The first thing I did was say, "Are you okay?" and she said, "Yes" and looked down at herself and brushed off her shirt. She was wearing a black short sleeved shirt with a V-neck. The kind of shirt you can get real cheap at Target or Walmart. She looked pretty good. She had on a necklace with some kind of fish symbol on it. She had jeans, and blue tennis shoes and a big backpack.

We just kind of looked at each other and didn't know what to say. So I finally said, "I work here, I'm just going to work. What is your name?"

"Sionna" she said.

"Sionna? That's different. I never heard of that. What does that mean?"

She started to tell me that her mom and dad named her after an Irish goddess, and then something about the River Shannon. I wasn't really listening though, because she had the coolest eyes I ever saw. They were a real light blue color, and reminded me of the sky, like right before the sun comes up, when it's still dark, but you can tell it's blue. I asked her if she wanted to come in and have some pizza. She said, "No thanks, I don't eat pizza, but if you want to go have a cup of coffee sometime, you can call me." I was a little freaked out. I never had a girl ask me out.

Not that she was really asking me out, but it kind of felt like that to me. It came out of her like it was no big deal. She spoke like cool blue, like the cool blue of her eyes. I got her phone number and told her I would call her later on.

Now, this might not seem weird to you, but like I said no girl has ever been interested in me. She was not what I would describe as being “cute” but I would say she was “pretty”. She had that real pale skin, the kind you would see in some kind of English story. Like one of those old stories from a long time ago, when women wore big huge dresses and piled their hair up on their heads. She should have been holding a fan or something.

When she walked away from me, she looked back over her shoulder kind of, like she was trying to remember what I was going to look like tomorrow when she wasn’t seeing me. It made me feel a little weird inside, like someone was lookin’ right through me or something. That wasn’t the weirdest thing though- here’s the weird thing that I can’t tell nobody. It was like I “knew” her or something. Like I had seen her somewhere before. But I didn’t, I would have remembered somebody like her. She seemed mysterious. I guess I would use a word here I have heard – intense-yea, that’s it, she was intense.

I just watched her walk away. She moved real smooth. It was like there wasn’t any bones in her body. It reminded me of the waves I saw when I went to the ocean out by New Jersey once. We had an aunt and uncle that lived out there, and before dad left, we went on a family vacation to see them. This was the only time I remember going on a vacation with my family. But anyway, we got to see the ocean. It was so cool. I thought the waves were the coolest thing I ever saw. I liked the way they sounded when they came up onto the land. That’s how I felt when I looked at her. I felt like when I stood at that one place with my feet in the sand and they said the tides were coming in....pretty soon you have to move up or you’ll get covered with water.

That was like Sionna, except she was washing up on me, and I didn't want to move my feet, I just wanted her to cover me completely.

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That day I met Sionna, when I got home, Ma was in a crazy mood. She was looking around the house mumbling to herself about trying to find her pain pills. She had her pills all out on the counter in a straight line so we didn't have to mess with trying to figure out what to give her everyday. She would take a pill from the front bottle, move it to the back of the line, and so on. She did pretty good with it. That was one thing she did remember. That way, I didn't have to be around constantly telling her what she was supposed to be taking.

She knew about this, but seemed confused.

"Ma, what's the matter?" I asked.

"I can't find my pain pills, I know I put them here somewhere. Did we go to church today? Did you see Mrs. Canasta there?"

Okay, this was definitely weird. We hadn't been to church for over fifteen years, and I aint seen Mrs. Canasta for at least the last year.

“Ma, what are you talking about? We don’t go to church anymore. Mrs. Canasta lives down one level, all’s you have to do is walk down there and see her if you want. Your pills are right in front of you in the box for today.”

She gave me this look I never saw before from Ma. Her eyes were all glassy and looked really empty. It was like she didn’t know who I was or something. She snapped out of it though, and said, “Oh, right, I am so sorry. I see them right here. I don’t know what got into me.”

Wow, she was losing it. I would have to tell Nick about this. I’m sure he’ll get mad or something –like it was my fault. Later on I went down to Joe’s to get a beer. I had to get out of the apartment. Ma was freaking me out. Chances are, I would see Nick down there. He always came down on Mondays to watch football on T.V. Everybody would sit around, or play pool, or darts, and start B.Sing about crap that went on that day. It made Mondays not seem so bad after all.

So I was sitting at the bar watching the Packers game – this was a big one against the Bears –when Nick came in. He slapped me on the back.

“Hey, little brother. What’s shakin’?” he said.

“I don’t know. Nothin’.”

“What’s the matter? I can tell you’re hidin’ something. What’s goin’ on?”

I told him the story of Ma being all confused. Like I thought, he started getting pissed off. “I knew she would start going crazy cooped up in that place all day” he said. “Why don’t you take her to the store or something? Holy Christ, do something with her before she turns into some demented old fart and we have to pay for a nursing home or something. I don’t have the money for that shit. Do you know how expensive that is? They take every last dime out of these old people, then leave the family in debt after they die. Is that what you want to happen?”

“Of course not. I just needed to get away from her for a while, that’s all.” He gave me that look like he wanted to punch me in the face. It was a little scary. I don’t think he would actually do it, but I’ve seen what he can do, and I don’t want that damage. He was right, of course, I did need to get home and watch Ma. I paid for my beer and told him I would watch it at home with her and I promised to get her out tomorrow and at least take a walk.

“That’s more like it,” he said.

God, sometimes I really hate Nick inside. I mean, he’s done so much for us, but at the same time, inside I really get tired of his shit. I would never tell anybody this, but I do get tired of it. It was freakin’ cold outside, and I walked a little faster than normal. When I looked up, I saw the library across the street and just halfway down the block. I should go in there, I thought. Who’s gonna know anyway? Ma can barely remember what the hell is going on, and Nick won’t know.

I walked real fast over there and saw they were open till 9 o’clock, so I had a little time. What do people do in here anyways? I started looking around. There were lots of tables with people sitting reading newspapers and magazines. Then there was a desk in the front where a lady was moving books around behind her. This place was much bigger than I thought. There was stairs going to another floor. The windows were really big and the floors must have been wood from a hundred years ago. It smelled kind of old, but there was something attractive about it too. Old lights hung down on metal chains from the ceiling over the tables and down the aisles with all the books in them. I started thinking if anyone had the time to read all the stuff in here. Probably not. You probably couldn’t read all this stuff in a million years. It would make people smarter though, I bet.

“How do I take a book home from here?” I asked the lady at the desk.

“Do you have a library card?” she asked.

“No, how do I get one of those?”

She showed me this piece of paper and I wrote down my name and address. Then she gave me a “temporary” paper card. She said a plastic one would be mailed to me within the week. That was cool, cause I got the mail anyway. It was like I could get anything in here for free. Who needed school anyway when you could get the same thing for free in the library? What stupid shit spends his money on classes when everything is right here, in this building?

I had no idea what I wanted in this place, but I just started walking down the rows looking at all the books. For some reason I ended up in the “classic literature” area and saw all these books by Shakespeare, Dickens, Eliot, Dumas, and Wilde. There was so many I didn’t know which one to pick out, but I thought they were all important if they were in that section, so I just picked out “Wuthering Heights” by a lady named Emily Bronte. I checked out the book with the lady at the desk, who gave me a thin little smile, and then walked home in the cold.

Shit, I missed the whole game. Just as well, Chicago won by a touchdown anyway. Ma was already in bed when I got there. Since there was nothing to do, I started reading that book. It was pretty weird at first, because it was about a place in England a long time ago. It was about a guy named Heathcliff and a girl named Catherine. So far, it was a little like a soap opera. There was a lot of people doing different things, but I got the feeling that these two really loved each other.

This reminded me of Sionna. I needed to call her, I thought I would do it in the morning since it was kind of late already. When I went to bed, I kept thinking of her. Somehow in my dream I mixed up Sionna and Catherine from the book. It was Sionna’s face, but she was

wearing old clothes, and riding horses and running through the outdoors all happy. I can't remember if I was in this or not. I just got this feeling though that I would end up feeling for her just like Heathcliff did in the book.

4

The next day I woke up and Ma was at the kitchen table drinking her coffee. We sat there as usual just looking at each other with nothing to say really. I asked her what she did last night. Why didn't she stay up till I got home? I tried to talk her into going for a walk. You would have thought I asked her to run a marathon or something. She gave me every excuse in the book.

"It's so cold outside. I don't have a nice coat to wear. Where are we going anyway?" It just went on and on and on. Finally, I just gave up. If Nick wants her to go outside so bad, then he can drag his ass over here and get her to go.

Of course, she probably would if Nick asked her. She listens to everything he says. He could ask her to swim across Lake Michigan, and she would probably try it for him. I swear sometimes, there's no reason for me being born anyway, except to have somebody for Nick to boss around. One time, Nick told her he was getting serious about this girl he had. Like that was really going to happen. Anyways, Ma went so out of her way to smother this girl, it was so ridiculous. Having her over for steak dinners, inviting her for Thanksgiving, and trying to meet her parents – the whole deal. She was so deep in this shit that when Nick broke it off (of course),

she went haywire. She didn't stop crying and sobbing for a week. I think she thinks she's never having any grandkids.

The more I thought about that whole situation, the more pissed off I got, so I told Ma I was leaving for a little while. I would see her in a couple hours. When I got outside, I found the phone number Sionna gave me. I was shaking and wondering if she would even remember me at all.

“Hi.”

“Hi, Sionna? This is the guy that got your number the other day outside of the pizzeria. Do you remember me?”

“Of course I do. How are you doing?” she asked.

“Fine, ummm, I was wondering if you want to go for that cup of coffee.”

“Absolutely.” She sounded so sure of herself, like she knew I was going to call at just that minute and had it all planned out.

We decided to meet downtown at a coffee shop called The Java Hut. I had seen this place, but never been in there. Mostly, because the people inside all looked like they were right out of a college magazine. Everybody carried around backpacks and textbooks. They sat around in groups talking about school and looking at their notes with each other, drinking coffee. Glasses sliding on and off of their heads as they made their points on different things they learned that day. It was just a little too cool for me, so I never stepped foot in the place – until now.

I walked in, and saw her near the wall in the back at a small table. She had a backpack too. What are we doing? Homework? I didn't care though, because when I looked at her I didn't see her washed out jeans, her soft leather shoes, or her long-sleeved loose green top with a hood.

All I saw were those eyes, they were like a watery blue crayon. When I looked into them, I lost all track of time and forgot who I was and what I was doing. I decided, she really was beautiful.

I asked her if she ever went to school. Of course she did. She had a degree in English and loved to read and write stories. Turns out she knew a lot about history and a million other things. I felt like a complete dumbass. I was sure she never wanted to see me again.

“What are you reading right now?” she asked.

Thinking of the good luck I had actually going to the library last night, I answered, “*Wuthering Heights*. It’s the story of this guy and girl and how they grew apart but were really in love with each other.”

“Yea, I know. I read it.”

Duh, how stupid of me. Of course she read it.

What happened over the next half hour, though, made me think about the book in ways I never could have imagined. She talked to me about symbols in the book: about ghosts, and double characters, and the moors. The environment of the book was like its people. They were wild and unpredictable and infertile. The love that Heathcliff has for Catherine never changes, but in the end that kind of love destroys him. A love that never changes will destroy you. It reminded me of the way Nick is; strong and unwavering, but somehow it seemed dumb. I wondered if it would destroy him in the end too.

Something inside of me was coming awake. It was something I never felt before. It was like I could talk to Sionna about anything and she wouldn’t think it was stupid. I wanted to be around her more, and talk to her more. She was so smart; even though smart isn’t the right word for it. She was interesting. More interesting than any person I ever met before in my life. She made me feel smarter just by being around her. I thought that was impossible, but I guess not.

Actually, I guess I was getting smarter by being around her, because she had a way of teaching me things I never knew I really wanted to know. But, the more she talked, the better I felt. We made another date to go to dinner on Friday night. I couldn't wait. As I walked away and down the street to the bus stop, I thought again about love that can end up killing you if you don't let it go where it's supposed to. Maybe that was Ma's problem all along. Dad left, and Ma never moved on. It just ended up destroying her. Even if dad came back today, Ma would probably still forgive him. Forgive him for all the pain, the extra work, and lack of money. Forgive him for missing out on his kids growing up, the baseball games, and graduations. Forgive him for not being there to support her when times were tough, and she didn't know what to do next. All she wants is that same guy, at that same time, doing that same thing he always did. I'm sure she wouldn't care about any of the crap, she'd just be happy.

Well, I knew one thing – there aint no way I could ever forgive him. He is the lowest of the low. He left his whole family and made them raise themselves. He didn't give two shits about us. Not to mention, it's because he left that I'm in the place I am. No college, not a decent job, and above all, I have to listen to Nick. Let's face it, Nick became my dad when I was eight. It's a damn shame.

I would never do that. I don't care if the woman I marry drives me freaking crazy, there's just no cause to leave. People have responsibility. It is a guy's duty to stand up for his family and take care of them. That's how good kids are made. For me, the more time you spend doing something, the better off that thing will be. If you want to be a body builder, you have to lift the weights every day. If you want to be a good mechanic, you got to work on cars every day. Practice really does make perfect. Hell, I make a good pizza because I do it every day. I'm not saying being a parent is easy. Shit no, I saw how Ma suffered. I'm just saying the more you

practice being a good parent, the better the kids will be in the end. Maybe that's why there's so many shitty people in the world, cause nobody is practicing being a parent.

5

The sun is shining through the trees. Millions of specks of sunlight shine down on me and around me. The forest is thick and lush green foliage brushes against the brown mare I ride on. This is a deciduous forest from long ago. Moss grows thick on the north sides of the beautiful muscled bark on the oak and maple species. Varied woodland plants adorn the forest floor. Wood sorrel grows thickly under the softly treading hooves of the horse. Trillium offer up their creamy white and pink colors, and bleeding hearts show vibrant purples and pinks. The smell is intoxicating, but not as intoxicating as the smell of her neck. Her long brown hair hangs limply down to the small of her back. I am sitting very close behind her, holding on around her waist. Occasionally, I lean forward to place my face next to her neck in order to smell her distinct scent. It was like a mix of rose and warm grass.

We traveled slowly through the underbrush toward an open field. The sun there was uninterrupted by any growth like the forest environment we had just emerged from. It was a warm day. Still – with the long blades of grass drooping slightly, inviting the small flying insects to alight on them, only to suddenly buzz frantically the next second to a new blade. We paused in the center of the grassy field and I jumped to the ground in order to help her down to meet me.

With arms outstretched, I notice the fine linen of my white sleeves, ballooning out in the open air. An embroidered red tunic covers my chest and torso, leading to the brown hose beneath. I reach for her, and lift her gently as she drops down from the trusty dappled mare we

rode upon. Her face is fair, heart-shaped, unlike the hundreds of everyday faces seen among our people. Something here stands out. I can feel such strong emotion, as if the connection between us is palpable electricity. The charge draws us towards each other and we embrace. I kiss her, and somehow I know this is the first kiss we have shared. It is the finest hour of my life. I am falling in love with this woman. Never have I been this vulnerable, allowing a woman to take all of my strength. I surrender completely and she is mine. I am drowning in her. I look into her eyes, and they are the lightest blue, like the early morning light.

“Hold!” I screamed, as I bolted upright in bed. My stomach was tight, my chest pounding like a drum. I was sweating, even though it was cold in my room. What the hell was that? I hardly ever dreamed anything. I remember it all though. There was a girl with me on the horse, a forest, and then we stopped in the field. I helped her off the horse and kissed her. The weird thing was the clothes. I really felt like I was in a movie about old kings and stuff. It was like it was my life for real. I knew that girl! It was Sionna, but in a different place with old clothes on. What is happening? Did I insert these people from life into some kind of *Wuthering Heights* book? That must have been it. The whole thing was make-believe. It had to be make-believe. Didn’t it?

As it turns out, there are a lot of people (I mean writers and such), who have said a lot of things about beauty. I read this in the library one day last week, “Everything has beauty, but not everyone sees it.” Well, I don’t know about that. The pizza parlor aint so beautiful, and neither is taking care of Ma, or Nick either. Hell, Nick doesn’t have one beautiful thing about him as far as I’m concerned. One thing I do know though, is somebody said that beauty is only skin deep, and that is definitely not true. I have started to find that some people are beautiful inside as well as out. Sionna is one of those people. I could talk to her all day and then some. After I talk to her, I have to have another day just to think about what we talked about. I told her about my crazy dream. She just smiled and looked through me with those watery eyes. She didn’t think it was crazy though.

She said that some people think dreaming is real, and being awake is not. What the hell?

“Did you know that Buddhists consider everything around us to be a dream?” she said.

I said, “I don’t get that. I’m sitting in a chair, I’m breathing air, and I’m looking at you. How could all this be just fake?”

“Well, it’s not fake, it’s just not something that will last for more than the present moment we are experiencing it. That doesn’t mean that it’s not a chair. It just means that soon it won’t be a chair. Once it was a tree, now it’s a chair, and someday it will just be rotted and return to the earth, to maybe grow into a tree again and start all over. The cycle of life is ever-changing. We have to be prepared to change with it, to be willing to let go of things, and also accept things that happen to us, without grasping onto them.”

We continue to talk about this for a while. She said some cultures believe we receive messages from spiritual guides while sleeping, or can tell the future through dreams, or just manage our thoughts so that we don't go nuts thinking about stuff day after day. Whatever dreams really are – or aren't – I did feel better talking to her about this.

“Maybe you were dreaming about something from a past life” she said.

Well, if that was a past life, I wish I could go back there. It was so beautiful, and peaceful. I liked being out in the open with the horse, and the girl – especially the girl. If that was me, was Sionna the girl in the dream? I really hoped so. Maybe that's why we got along so well. Nobody ever wanted to talk to me about my dreams before. She made me feel like I belonged somewhere; like I really mattered. I wasn't just a guy who make pizzas, or somebody that took care of my Ma, or somebody's pesky little brother. For once I felt like I was important in some way. I just wasn't sure what way yet.

If people were measured by the beauty inside of them, instead of outside, Sionna would be a “10” for sure. I'm not saying that she's not good looking either, because she is. I'm just saying the more you're around her, the more beautiful she becomes. I started to think that being blind might not be so bad if I had someone like her around me to talk to. I didn't even have too many thoughts yet about sex with her. I thought about it when I wasn't around her, but when we did see each other, we got so busy talking, that it just wasn't in my head, if you know what I mean. When we talked about something, I would go to the library and try to read about it, so I wouldn't feel so dumb. The thing is, I started to really like reading about all sorts of stuff. Talking about dreams made me read about Sigmund Freud. He was this German guy who started the whole “psychotherapy” thing. He came up with the ego, and dream analysis. It seems like everything he talked about was sexual. He thought that dreams told us what was in our

subconscious, the stuff in our heads we don't always know is there. If that's true, then in my subconscious I want to ride a horse, live in olden times, and fall in love with a girl. Sounds good to me.

Sionna and I continued to meet on a regular basis. Most of the time, we just sat around and talked at the Java Hut, or walked in the park, or went to museums. Let's just say I hadn't spent much time hanging out in museums as a kid. Hell, I only went in one if there was a field trip or something I had to do in school. It got pretty interesting though. Seems to me that a lot of these old painters were crazier than shit. Either they were alcoholics, or committed suicide, or cut their ears off or something. Sionna said something like, "intelligence borders insanity" or something like that. I think I've never known anyone smart enough to be considered insane, just insane people who were also dumb. Which leads me to telling you about the weirdest thing I've ever done, so far. I could never tell anybody, because then I would be one of those insane people.

I found myself lying on a purple rectangle mat closing my eyes and thinking about breathing. I felt like the stupidest person on earth. The funny thing was, there were about twenty other people lying there doing the same thing I was. I don't know how she talked me into this one, but I tried yoga. She told me it was centuries old, and could help me calm my mind, increase my lung capacity, and help me stay young forever physically. Sounded like a miracle drug or something. I was wearing a t-shirt, and shorts, which, as it turns out, is not exactly the thing to wear to yoga. There is a lot of leaning upside down, spreading your legs apart, and this

weird doggie position, where my shirt kept falling down over my face. I had to finally tuck the shirt into my pants so I could see what was going on. I thought yoga sounded pretty easy. You stand, you sit, you lay down - whatever. What I found out was this crap was *hard*. During it I felt completely out of breath all the time, dizzy half the time, and just plain out of shape. My groins felt like someone pulled me apart, just like a stretch Armstrong. My lower back was aching, and my shoulders hurt. I couldn't do all the push-up things, so I felt like a wimp.

Here's the weirdest thing of all though - after it was over, I felt so relaxed, like I just woke up after sleeping all night. And talk about calm, I wouldn't care if someone called me or Nick a big pussy right to our faces. I just wouldn't care at all. What's that about? I didn't feel violent, or mad, or really anything. Just calm. Not that I'm the meanest person anyway, but I usually would stand up for myself for cryin' out loud.

"You were really great at that" Sionna said.

"Are you kidding me?"

"No, you caught on very quickly, and I have the feeling you liked it. You did like it, didn't you?"

"Um, yeah. Yeah! I did like it! I just felt so dumb. I don't know why."

"That's pretty common for the first few times. You'll get the hang of it, and then you'll understand the process", she said.

"What do you mean, the process?"

"Well, it's true what they say. Your practice is your practice. The only thing that matters is what's going on on your mat. Pretty soon you won't even notice anyone else or what they're doing."

"Yeah, well, my practice is not the best practice."

"That's why they call it 'practice', haha."

We both smiled at that one. I guess if all I'm doing is practicing, then I never have to be perfect. Also, I guess no one is ever "done". I had to hurry up and go home to change for work. It was the best night of work ever. I can't explain it, but making pizzas didn't bother me. Cleaning up didn't bother me. The asshole customers didn't bother me. Nothing. I was just happy to be there, which I don't think has ever happened to me before, unless you count payday, when I was just happy to be getting a check.

8

Geez, Nick is pissed off. I get home and he's stomping around the place getting Ma all upset about something. Seems I haven't been around a lot, and he's mad at me. He gives me this look like he wants to kill me or something. I don't know what to say. I'm trying not to cringe, but he's so mad.

"What's going on Nick?" I ask, trying to keep as calm as possible. I don't want to look afraid in front of him. It's just not cool.

"Ma missed her doctor's appointment yesterday, you ass. Where the hell were you? Don't you remember your responsibilities around here? Now we have to wait two more weeks because they can't fit her in. What were you doing yesterday that was so important anyway?" His lips were in a tight line, and his face was getting red. I could see him clenching his fists, moving them in and out.

“I totally forgot. I’m sorry, I was with someone” I said.

“With someone? What the hell is that? With who?” Nick was trying not to lose it completely, and Ma just sat in her chair looking at us like nothing was up.

“I met a girl, and we had a couple dates. That’s all.”

Nick just stared at me with those black eyes and fire coming out the top of his head. “Oh, great. A girl. That’s worth all this. Don’t you think Ma deserves better than that? Try looking at your priorities Bro, you just might learn something.”

“I said I was sorry!” I was trying to explain, but he just turned around and walked out, slamming the door in my face.

That’s all I need. Nick mad at me. What a mess this was. I would have to talk to him soon, because I didn’t know when I would have to get Ma to the doctor now. I thought maybe tomorrow or the next day I would call him and see if he would even speak to me. I hardly ever get into it with Nick. I just don’t like arguing with people – especially Nick. He’s responsible and everything, but you just don’t know what he is going to do.

One time, back when he was in high school, I remember him getting so pissed off at this one kid named Steve. I think Steve said something mean to Nick’s girlfriend, and she came to him crying about it. Nick was so mad. He went over to that kid’s house in the middle of the night, took a can of lighter fluid, and sprayed it around his front yard a little bit, then he set that crap on fire! I couldn’t believe it. And he got away with it too. One of his friends was there and saw him do it, but like I said, everybody is afraid of Nick, so the guy said nothing. I didn’t find out until Nick told me one night at the bar a couple years ago. What a set of balls. I am usually proud that Nick is my brother, but the question is, would I want Sionna to meet Nick? I can’t imagine they could even communicate with each other. He is so off the handle, and she has

herself together so well. He wouldn't even understand her, and she definitely might be afraid of him, I know I would if I was a girl.

In my mind I was trying to figure out how I could make all the people in my life fit together. Ma, Nick, Sionna; they are all so different. Each one needs some special thing, some special care. Ma needs me. She needs me to take her places, make sure she gets medicine and her pills. She can't even be trusted to sleep alone. Nick needs me because he needs me to take care of Ma. Sionna needs me. Sionna needs me? Where did I get that one? Maybe I was just hoping she needs me, without really knowing. It's true she tells me stuff that makes me feel that way. She says I give her "insight". Not sure how I do that. The other day we were talking about trees and how they change color in the fall. She told me the sugars get caught in the leaves. It's like the trees are shutting down for the winter. The sugars get caught in the leaves and it makes them turn spectacular colors. I said something like, "Sometimes when people get caught in bad situations, they change into something better – just like leaves." She said that was beautiful. I never had anyone tell me that something I said was beautiful before.

Come to think of it, I didn't remember Ma or Dad or Nick ever telling me anything too great. Ma would say that I was helpful around the house. I was her "little helper" way back when. I didn't mind. I figured Ma needed all the help she could get, especially after Dad left. Then there was Nick. He and me - we were always a team as far as he was concerned. When we were little, we would pretend to be super heroes or ninjas out to conquer the world together. He was always the leader, and I was the follower. When I had an idea of my own, he wouldn't play, so I just let him take the lead role. He still is like that. I can't tell you the last time he actually let me do something without his say-so. It was starting to piss me off a little bit.

"You need to work less night shifts so you can be home to watch Ma."

“You have to stop worrying about owning a car. I have one and you live close enough to work to ride the bike.” He was always saying crap like that.

I don’t know. Someday I swear I’m gonna have a better job, a house of my own, a car, and hopefully a girl just like Sionna. I have to get out of here. I’m going to the library.

9

I ended up in a section of the library with exercise books, and there in front of me were lots of book on yoga, so I picked one out. Next to this I came across a section on world religion. I had never thought too much about religion, but my mind drifted back to a couple conversations Sionna and I had about Buddhist thinking, so I checked out one of those too. She wanted me to keep going to yoga with her. I have to tell you I was happy to do it. It felt weird at first, like my body was made of metal pipes and everyone else’s was made of bendable pipe cleaners, but hey, that’s okay. She said we all start out stiff and the more you go, the more bendable you become. We’ll see about that I guess.

I started to read the book about Buddhism. It made me stop and think. This part I read was about attachment, and how attaching ourselves to other people or things will make us miserable and cause suffering. The problem is that we are all looking for happiness, and the book says we look for happiness in the outside world, instead of realizing that the way we think about things can make us happy. People start wishing for more money and houses and stuff, when all that does is cause suffering, because people are missing the point. The more they have, the more

they want, and that leads to never-ending searching for more stuff, or “happiness”. The point is that all things are really one thing. It says that we are not separate from all other things – there is no separation to begin with, so we can end our quest for things outside of us, because things are all inside of us. I was trying to understand this. It said that meditating on the present moment is the best way to come to this “realization”. It said that Buddhism is about practicing these thoughts, not about just believing something, but really “experiencing” it. It said that life is suffering, and the cause of suffering is the search for things. Once we have things, they change, which leads to more suffering. It did say there was hope though. The hope was that through meditation and changing our minds, we can release ourselves from suffering, because we become enlightened and live only for the present moment. That was really cool. I never thought about things like this before. I had to talk to Sionna about it.

I called her up and told her I wished she would finally come over to my place, and even meet my Ma. She wasn’t really surprised, just a little hesitant. She said, “Are you sure? It’s kind of a big deal to meet your mother.”

“Hell, she probably won’t even remember meeting you when she wakes up the next morning. She’s so forgetful now” I responded.

We talked a little more.

“What I really need to talk to you about is some stuff I read in a book about Buddhism.”

“Oh” she responded. “I didn’t know you were interested in Buddhism.”

“Well, remember when we were talking about meditating?” I said.

“Sure.”

“I think I want to try it sometime.” I felt a little stupid about saying it, but it was true. I felt like since I met Sionna, I wanted to try new stuff. I wanted to feel things that I never felt

before. I wanted to feel how I felt when I was with her – fresh, new, and looking forward to the future. I suddenly felt that I was growing up or something. I was starting to feel like a real person. I mean, it's not like I wasn't a real person. That would be dumb to think. But, a person by myself - without Nick, without Ma, without my job and apartment and belongings. It was just me – a person by myself.

“You’ve already tried it silly”, she said.

“What are you talking about?”

“You are meditating at the end of every yoga practice. You know, when we just lie there at the end – in Savasana, or corpse pose.”

She was right, of course. At the end of every yoga class, we have to just lie there and close our eyes. Your body is so tired of moving and stretching, it's like a huge relief to do it. Your brain thinks of all kinds of stuff, but then, there's just peace. Now I knew that I could do this at home. I could sit in a chair, or lay on my bed, or on the floor and just “zone out”. I was ready to zone out.

When I hung up the phone, I went out to the living room to sit with Ma. She was watching one of her crazy game shows.

“How's it goin' Ma?” I said.

“What? Oh, it's you.” She had this funny confused look to her, almost like she didn't know me or something.

“Are you okay Ma?” I started to get worried.

“Oh, I don't know. It just feels like my heart is going to jump out of my chest! It's so strange, the feeling I have right now. I'm a little dizzy too.”

I didn't like the sound of that. I decided to call Dr. Carson. He had been seeing Ma for the last ten years or so. The nurse told me I should bring her in that afternoon. That was just great. I was going to have to call in sick for work, so I could get Ma to the doctor. Nick wouldn't be out of work for a while, and we had to ride the bus about three miles to the office. Whatever. I get so sick of doing this shit. I didn't sign up to be a nurse, but it sure feels like I am.

When we got to the doctor's office, I sat in a chair by the window and stared outside. The sky was grey, with clouds hanging low. There were people walking down the street, and the sound of a siren somewhere off in the distance. All of a sudden the nurse called my name. I almost jumped out of my chair. I think I really did zone out there for a minute. I followed her back to one of the room down the hallway. I walked in and Dr. Carson came toward me.

"Hello, I'm Dr. Carson. I think I may have met you before. You're the younger son, right?"

"Yeah, that's right. Uh, how's she doin' Doc?"

"Well, that's what I wanted to discuss with you. Your mother is fine. She is settled in another room. The thing is, I want to talk to you about her blood pressure."

"Her blood pressure? What's the matter with it? She's been takin' her pills. I know it, I make sure she takes them religiously."

The doctor looked me straight in the eye, with a very serious look. Then he says, "Your mother's blood pressure is dangerously high. It's so high, I'm afraid of the risk of a stroke. My advice is that you take her directly to the emergency room and we admit her for observation. She will receive blood pressure medicine intravenously until we can get her stabilized."

“Whoa man. I can’t believe this. Are you sure it’s that bad?” I said. This was the last thing I expected, or hell, needed, today. That’s it, I was going to have to call Nick to leave work and pick us up.

“Your mother has been confused, is that right? And she also experienced chest pressure this afternoon?” He was starting to write stuff down on a paper pad in front of him.

“Yeah, that’s right. She hasn’t been acting to normal lately.” I hated to tell him the hundreds of times she didn’t act normal. I forgot what it was like for her to act normal anyway. I thought of Ma and all the years I had known her. She was always quiet, but when she talked to us, she always had something to say that really made sense. She was, as far as I could remember, the most reasonable member of the family. But now, now she rambles on about shit that no one cares about, people that are dead, and stuff that happened a long time ago, like it just happened yesterday. She was definitely off her rocker, and we had to get her back on.

I talked to the doctor some more, called Nick (who was pissed, of course), and arranged to take her into the emergency room. Dr. Carson called the hospital and told them she was coming. Nick shows up and asks, “What the hell is this all about now?” and we explained the situation. Ma didn’t seem too concerned. She did keep holding onto her chest and saying that she heard ringing in her ears. “Someone must be talking about me.” She said. That’s right Ma, we’re all talking about you. We got her in the car and took off.

It turned out they only kept Ma in the hospital for three days. Nick tried to come when he was off work, but I was there pretty much all of the time, and went to work in the afternoon. Sionna met me at the hospital one day for lunch and we walked outside and around the neighborhood. It did my mind a load of good to get out of that place. Hospitals are so depressing. When I saw Sionna though, my heart did a little dance in my chest. Her eyes sparkled like diamonds. I know that sounds really queer, but it's true. Her eyes did look like light blue diamonds. She made me feel excited and calm all at the same time. Excited because I couldn't wait to see her again when she left. Calm because she had this way of talking to me that made me feel really special – like I was the only guy in the world she wanted to talk to. That never happened to me before. All this was new, and I loved it. Actually, I think I loved her, I just hadn't told her yet.

I fell asleep in the chair in Ma's room after Sionna left on the second day Ma was there. In the dream I was a soldier of some sort. I just remember there was total chaos around me. *People were yelling and screaming. Blood was on the ground. Blades of shining steel were being thrust around and into other men. I felt exhausted and sad. I had just killed a man and was standing over his body. He tried to talk, but the only word that came out was "Save her" and blood bubbled out of his mouth. I was confused and trying to understand what he was talking about. Who is "her"? Just as I stood to walk away, I turned slowly around to my left and in the middle of dozens of men screaming and falling, Nick was running towards me.*

"Nick! Nick! Thank God you're here! I thought I was going to die."

“That you are little brother” he hissed at me, and then suddenly stabbed the longest knife I have ever imagined into my chest. I couldn’t believe it. Nick had killed me – Nick had killed me.

I woke up gasping for breath; my heart pounding in my chest. I was still at the hospital. Ma was dozing off in her bed. That was the weirdest thing ever. I still felt like it was real. Why would Nick want to kill me? Me? His little brother. I felt betrayed and so confused. It took me a good fifteen minutes to come out of it and tell myself it was only a dream. Still, for the rest of the day I had an awful feeling. It was the feeling of betrayal by my closest family member. That had to be the worst betrayal of all.

I didn’t have much time to think about this weird dream, because I was getting Ma all set up to come home. The nurses and Dr. Carson spent a lot of time with me, making sure I knew how important it was for Ma to stay on her blood pressure medications. She also had some pills called Nitro, that she could use in case she had chest pain. It didn’t sound like they were as worried about a heart attack as they were about her stroking out from her high blood pressure. She also had a little bit of what they call “dementia”, or as far as I can describe it, just old people’s brain. Sionna went with me to the drug store and we bought a plastic container labeled with all the days of the week, Sunday through Saturday. This way, we could put all of Ma’s pills for the week inside, and nobody would get confused (like her). I felt pretty good about all of it really. For the first time in my life, things were starting to go right. I was going to be responsible for keeping Ma alive. I had a girlfriend that really liked me. My Ma liked her too, I think. As far as Nick goes, that one I’m not so sure about. He hadn’t met Sionna yet, and I was in no big hurry for that. I loved my brother, but he could be pretty harsh. I didn’t want her to run away because of him.

Later that night, while Sionna went to her philosophy class, I got Ma all tucked in, explained to her the pill routine, and showed her the container. “See Ma, right here is every day of the week, and every day will have the pills in in you need. There’s even separations for morning and night”

“Oh my Lord, that looks a little overwhelming” she said eyeing the plastic blue container suspiciously.

“No worries Ma. I’m goin’ to be here to make sure everything is okay, and make sure you get the right pill at the right time.”

She looked up at me with those tired brown eyes of hers. “You’re such a good boy. You and Nick are like a God-send to me. What would I do without you two?”

I had to think to myself. “You two?” Like Nick was ever around anymore to take care of anything. That was a laugh. The only thing Nick did lately was criticize me for anything he could think of. Speak of the Devil, in walked Nick. His face was the usual beet red, eyes wild with some kind of inner rage. His hair all helter-skelter was framing his pox-marked face. I swear sometimes he looked like he came straight out of prison. Like he just broke loose and was looking for vengeance – a kind of vengeance you see in a war movie.

“What’s up little Bro? You got Ma all tucked in? Man, you shoulda been a nurse!” he laughed so loud I thought he would wake Ma up.

“Knock it off man. Somebody has to make sure she stays on track. Where have you been?” I sounded accusingly.

“Don’t start giving ME shit Bro. Where the hell do you think? I was at work. More than you can say for your sorry ass down at that bullshit pizza parlor job.” His face got redder by the minute.

“I know, I know, just sayin’, it’s eight o’clock at night Man. Ma’s been home for like four hours.”

“All right, look” said Nick, “I’m not giving you hell. Just what is the deal around here anyway? Are you going to keep her from strokin’ out, or what?” He settled himself down in the overstuffed brown chair, kicking his big booted feet onto the footstool.

“Well, that is what I’m tryin’ to do. Look – I got her meds all in the same spot, and told her I would help her keep track of everything. Check it out.” I handed him the blue medication container.

“Oh, holy shit! Aren’t you nurse Nancy! Well, well, how did you come up with this little idea anyway?” His smirk was starting to really piss me off, not to mention the way he said it. If he wasn’t so Goddamn big, I could of hauled off and clocked him in that smug face of his.

“If you must know, Sionna helped me figure it out. She’s really smart and good at that shit. You know I never could think things through.”

Mockingly Nick replied, “If you must know, if you must know. Whatever. This chick sure has you wrapped around her finger. I mean, if you must know.”

“Stop it Nick! You haven’t even met her. I don’t understand how you can’t like someone you don’t even know, Man. Give her a fuckin’ break!” I said, trying to keep my voice down, but practically spitting on him.

“Don’t you talk to me like that, you little bastard.” Nick spit back, suddenly standing up and looking like the giant red Viking that he was.

“I’m not a bastard!”

“How the hell do you know? Maybe you are. You sure are a giant pussy – and that makes you and me way different Bro.”

“You’re so Goddamn hateful. What the fuck got into you? Was Ma on crack or somethin’ when she was pregnant with you?” I started screaming. My fists were closed tight and I wanted to punch something. Anything.

Whack! Nick’s hand slapped me across the head. My left ear was ringing, and I suddenly felt very sick. “Don’t you EVER talk that way about MY mother you little fuck.” He spun around and stomped out, slamming the door behind him. Christ, what just happened? I had never been in a screaming fight with Nick before. Hell, I never had the nerve to. It just came bubbling out of me like I had been holding it down forever. Bubbling out like a box of firecrackers exploding out of my mouth. It was okay anyway. Who needs Nick, really? Me and Ma and Sionna would be just fine without him. In that split second, I knew I never wanted Sionna to meet that prick.

PART TWO

1.

It was the most perfect spring day. We were at the tail-end of the school year with only a week before summer break. The lilac bushes were blooming at the back edge of the school property. I was almost out of fourth grade. Me and Bobby Swenson were laughing our asses off, folded over at the waist, grabbing our sides before they split out. Jennifer Bales and Sue Something-or-other were looking at us with stern faces and shaking their heads.

“You guys are in so much trouble when Mrs. Stark finds out you’re making fun of her” Jennifer said with her know-it-all voice. She was like a forty year old stuck in the body of a nine year old. Her brown braids ended halfway down her back with the flail of red bows that bounced off her when she walked. She and Sue walked toward the building, probably on the way to report our goofy behavior to Mrs. Stark.

“You HAVE to learn some responsibility!” I cried, barely able to spit the words out through the raucous laughter.

“No, YOU have to learn some responsibility!” Bobby spit out, his face red and dribble running out of his mouth from the uncontrolled giggling.

“Learn some responsibility, learn some responsibility!” we cried in unison, mocking Mrs. Stark’s earlier comment in the classroom directed towards us both. We had been sending notes under the desk to one another, putting pencil eraser tips up our noses, and acting like tyrannosaurus rex monsters coming to life. Generally the type of things boys do at the end of the

school year when we got tired of long division and trying to write paragraphs with three parts. It was total relief. Total uncontrollable joy bubbling up from the far reaches inside, telling the world “we’re almost free! Hee hee!”

Apparently Mrs. Stark didn’t see it that way. We had been getting on her bad side for the last week or so. She was at the end of her rope. Ma got a call from her the other night, and told me if I didn’t straighten out and “fly right” I would be punished. She would take my bike away for a week. Crap, I didn’t want that to happen. But, I just couldn’t help myself today. Everything Bobby and I saw, or heard, was absolutely hilarious. I saw Nick from the corner of my eye. He was walking toward us; hair in a devilish mess. “What are you two numbskulls doin’?” he asked looking around for a clue.

Bobby just looked at me nervously, seemingly muted by Nick’s presence. Nick was a big bad-assed sixth-grader. He was at the top of the totem pole in our school. Not only was he in the senior class, he was tall, and big, and highly respected for his bravery in every situation. Since Bobby wasn’t going to answer, I said, “Oh, just the usual crap from Mrs. Stark. She thinks we need to learn some responsibility”. The last two words came out slow with a muffled sputter before I burst into laughter again, my face red, and tears starting to form in the corners of my eyes. Nick slapped me across the shoulder. “Little Bro, you better start listening, man. Ma is pissed at you already. Don’t get sent to the principal’s office.”

“I know – I know. Just have to stop laughing.” I looked at Bobby, and he just stared wide-eyed toward the building. As I looked up, I saw Mrs. Stark strutting up to us, glasses hanging from her beaded necklace on top of her big boobs.

“Mr. Olsen! Mr. Olsen!” she started declaring as she got closer.

“Would you like to explain yourself to me before I send you in to talk to Mr. Pauls?”

Mr. Pauls was the principal, and he sure wasn't a "pal". He was kind of a big prick. He didn't like getting into it with arguing kids, and he really didn't like getting into it with disrespectful kids and their parents.

"Um, sorry Mrs. Stark" Nick interrupted. "He didn't mean anything by it. He and Bobby were just goofing around. You should see them around my house. It never ends. I'll talk to him and Ma will talk to him. He'll never act up in class again. I guarantee it."

Mrs. Stark put her glasses on, tipping her head at just the right angle so she could get a good head-to-toe of Nick. Actually, he might have been just an inch taller than her. "Well, Nick, I know you're a good student. It's too bad your brother here doesn't have the same level head as you. It's been such a pleasure having you at the school. We will be sorry to see you go. I guess I'll let it pass this time." Then she turned to me, "YOU, young man, need to follow your brother's example and start paying attention. And you, Bobby, your mother will be getting a little note from me also." She turned on her heels like a Nazi in one of those old World War II movies, and marched back up to the school.

"Nick, um thanks man. You saved my skin" I said. Bobby just looked at him and said, "Yeah Nick. Thanks a lot. My mom would be so upset if Mr. Pauls called her." Nick just smirked and stared at us with a look of warning.

"You two knock it off. That is the last time I'm getting involved in your stupid crap." He walked off toward a group of three other sixth-graders who were all asking what just happened. Of course, Nick would be the star of the show; the guy who stood up to Mrs. Stark. The guy who saved his little brother's ass. It made me love him. It made me hate him. If they only knew the kind of stuff he did. He stole stuff, and made fun of people. He was a bully sometimes, and nobody even cared to say it. It was like Nick lived in a bubble, and no one could touch him. It

was like he could just go around doin' whatever he wanted, and everything would be okay. It was like he was magic or something.

Later that night, Nick came into my room and asked how the rest of the day went.

"Oh, it was okay. Thanks again for standing up to Mrs. Stark for me."

"So what was the joke anyway?" he asked.

"She was telling us we needed to learn responsibility. But it just wasn't that, it was the way she said it. It was just really funny at the time." I was at a loss for words, because now it didn't seem funny at all, when it had seemed hilarious earlier.

"You're such a numbskull, man." He reached over and mussed up the hair on the top of my head. "I'll always take care of you. Don't forget that."

"I won't Nick. I won't"

I found myself staring out the front window of the pizza parlor. The grass was turning green, and the weather was getting warmer. That must have been what triggered the memory of Nick and me in grade school. I just sighed, a slight grin on my face. He had always been the alpha dog of the family. Well, actually, he had always been the alpha dog in any group he had ever been a part of. I don't think Sionna really got the full gist of this. She hadn't met Nick yet. So far, I had managed to keep them apart. But I knew sooner or later, they would end up in the same place. They were both the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end – of me anyway. What I mean is, both of them completed me in some way. Just really different ways. He was the leader, the supporter, the pusher, I guess. She was the soft part of my life, my comfort, and inner strength. Without both of them, who would I be? Who would I be? That was the question I had to ask myself.

A couple months had gone by since my fight with Nick. He was now avoiding us like the plague. He can over to see Ma about once a week, but barely said anything to me now. If he did, it was something smartass, like “how's that girlfriend of yours Bro? Hope you're getting something from her, your nose is nice and brown.” He was always saying some stupid crap like that. I just ignored him for the most part. Actually, Nick wasn't bothering me that much anymore. Since I had started meditation, and been doing it on a regular basis, things weren't so critical. Things happened, but my reaction to the things that happened weren't sudden and reactive. I was learning to control the way my mind thought about things. I could “see” my mind like I was watching a movie. I could see what I was thinking and feeling, and then I was able to

control where those emotions were going. It was like being my own monitor. It was pretty useful really.

I could see that a lot of what Nick once meant to me was kind of silly, in a way. He was not the all-powerful beast people cracked him up to be. He was not my best friend, or my biggest fear. Nick was just a person. I am just a person, and on and on and on. No one is more powerful than I am, or less powerful than I am. I guess we all have inner strength. We just need to figure out how to use it. Ma was doing okay. We had her medication down to a science now, with all the pills laid out for each day, and for the time of day she needed them. She was often confused, but able to remember what happened for short periods most of the time. The best part was, she really loved Sionna. She asked me when she was coming over, what she was going to cook (when she did), and told me how “nice” and “polite” she was. It made me happy inside. To actually feel like I was being valued for a decision that I had made, not that Nick made, but that I had made, felt awesome.

Nick came over to visit last night. He walked in with his big boots and brown suede jacket, threw his keys into the basket next to the front door, and bent down to kiss Ma. She peeled her eyes away from the T.V. long enough to kiss his cheek and ask how his work was.

“Oh, you know, it was okay I guess. Those assholes next to me in the line almost caught me in the goddamn drill press today. I told them to pull their heads outta’ their asses and start doin’ their jobs before someone gets killed down there.”

“Nick, do you have to swear? It’s so unlike you.” Ma said with her saggy puppy eyes.

“Okay, okay, Ma. No, I won’t swear in front of ya; don’t want to hurt your pretty ears.” Ma smiled in her hesitant way. She turned back to the T.V. not wanting to miss the end of her cop show.

“So, what’s up with you?” he said, pressing his lips into a strange pursed curl.

“Ah, not much. Just working and thinking about going to school” I said. I was expecting a huge knee-slapping laugh from Nick, but he just stared at me silently contemplating what I had just said.

“Going to school? How the hell are you going to pay for that? And what for?” His look displayed an incomprehensible expression, as if he had just heard Ma was pregnant or something.

“Well, I decided that there’s a lot of good jobs out there, but I have to have a degree to do anything worth doing, so I’m going to the community college and getting a bachelor’s degree in business. Maybe I can manage a restaurant or someplace like that.” I waited for his arguments.

“How the hell will you pay for it? How the hell are you going to have time to watch Ma if your screwing around with those pencil-pushers?” His eyes looked like they were set on fire.

“Sionna told me I could qualify for a low-interest student loan. I checked it all out, and applied for it, and they gave me the money. I mean, really, community college isn’t that much compared to other places.”

Nick cut me short. “Whoa, whoa, whoa dude. You have really done it now. I can’t believe you are letting this chick tell you what to do. It’s not like she’s gonna be around to help pay this shit back! That’s all on your head man. I can tell you one thing, it sure ain’t gonna be me helping your sorry ass out when you finish – IF you finish- and then have a huge debt and no job. Hope you keep your place at the pizza joint, or you’re really gonna be sorry.” His eyes were wild with exaggeration as he rolled them around the room.

I had to hand it to Nick, he never lost his personality, never slid out of his slick, macho attitude of Mr. Know-it-all, never. I just looked at him. “I have to tell you that first of all, I don’t

want to work in a pizza place my whole life. Second, I don't do everything Sionna tells me, this was my idea. And lastly, it would really mean a lot to me if you could just step up and be on my side for once, you know? You are my brother, man." I was trying not to lose my cool composure, because we really needed to work things out. I needed him to work with me on this.

"Be on your side? Be on your side?" he said with an elevating voice.

"Man, do you actually remember your own life? How many times have I saved your ass? I mean really, can you keep count?"

Ma was starting to notice there was something unusual going on. She looked up with a confused, creased forehead. She started nodding her head side to side, as if to say, "Please don't argue boys." Slowly, she returned her eyes back to the television screen and folded her hands in her lap.

"I know, Nick, I know. I'm not saying that. What I mean is, I really need my family to support me on this. It's going to be really hard, and take a lot of time. I will be here for Ma. Classes aren't all day. I have to be in and out of here. I'll make sure she's okay."

Nick looked pensive. "Do you remember that time in high school when Donny Amstel started harassing you? He was pushing you in the locker room after gym class and calling here hanging up, and threatening to steal your bike? Do you remember all that?"

"Yeah, sure, I do remember that. You told me you would take care of it, and then, all of a sudden, he just stopped talking to me altogether. He wouldn't even look at me."

"Do you know what happened?" Nick said smirking.

"Not really. What did you do?" I almost didn't want to know.

"Well," he said leaning in toward me and lowering his voice so Ma couldn't hear, "I followed him home from school one day. As he was going into his house, I ran up and shoved

my body in his front door, so he couldn't close it. Oh God man, he looked like he was about to shit his pants." Nick started giggling like a little kid. "Then – then, oh man. Then, I told him if he ever threatened you like that again he would be killed. I told him our family had mafia connections. And he believed me! He was so scared, I couldn't believe he actually believed me. What a dumbass! It worked though, right?" He looked so proud of himself right then.

"It did work Nick, it did." I had to snicker too. The thought of us being connected to the mafia was the craziest thing ever. We were about as far from Italian as you could get. I mean, if there was a Viking mafia organization, then maybe. I just smiled at him. "You are something else man."

He hit me lightly on the arm. "You're not just my brother man, you're my best friend." That completely caught me off guard. I hadn't ever thought about it, but I guess we were pretty good friends. I guess I could consider Nick to be my best friend. All my friends from high school were getting married, and having kids. I was friends with some of the guys at work, but none of them were that great of friends. Nick and me, we had a history all right. I just smiled at him.

"Just remember this Bro, nothin', I mean *nothing* is ever gonna come between us. You get me man? You get me? Not school, not Ma, and not this girl either. I mean, I get it. I get that she's your girlfriend. But bro's before ho's. You know what I mean?" Nick just sneered at me with a thin, greasy smile. I wanted to scream inside. Who the hell is he to call my girlfriend a "ho"? I know it was a generalization, but really. Nick needed to grow up. I just kept it under wraps and smiled back at him. "Sure Nick, sure. I get you man" was all I said.

My first class was a college level English class. We were going to have to write a lot, and apparently read a lot too. It was all leading up to a long essay at the end of the semester. We had to present an argument, and support it with research and what-not. It had been over a decade since I was in a classroom. I thought I would be the oldest one there, but was shocked to look around and see quite a few middle aged people, even a grandma or two. This got my hopes up. Maybe I wouldn't have as much trouble as these older folks, I mean, hell, at least I had been there closer than they had. We went to the library on campus and rummaged through the reference section, listened to the librarian talk about resources, and that kind of thing. It wasn't so bad really. There were a few cute girls in there; just a few really. They were mostly younger than me. They weren't as pretty as Sionna, though. But then when they opened their mouths – oh God! The stupid shit that came out was amazing. It was like they didn't talk about anything but their clothes, their hair, nails, blah, blah, blah. I couldn't believe the difference between them and Sionna. She was a rocket scientist compared to these chicks.

I had to get a computer to do all this work at home. Sionna hooked me up with this guy who was selling his, and I got him to come over and set it up in my bedroom. Ma was confused out of her mind. "What's going on? What is that thing? Why do you need that?" The questions kept coming. Let's face it, people were starting to use computers, and Ma had never even set eyes on one. No one used them when she worked at the school, and she hadn't had a grip on the present situation for a while. I was able to write papers, and journal on it. I couldn't surf though, I had to be at school in the computer lab for that. But what the hell? It was better than nothing. I found myself writing a lot more than I really needed to. Between school, Ma, Sionna, and my

job, I was getting very little sleep, and when I did sleep, I slept hard. I didn't mind it though. Every day I woke up with a purpose, which was a lot different than the way I used to wake up. My purpose was taking care of Ma, learning, and loving Sionna. Me and her were getting to know each other better and better all the time. She helped me with my homework. It was like she actually enjoyed it, even though I knew she already learned this stuff. Her brain was like a steel trap; she remembered everything she ever learned. I wish I could become like that. She told me that learning was like meditating. You have to focus on one thing, and that thing only. If you did this, you would never forget. She told me the ancient Tibetans had a way of remembering things. They pretended to see a big library in their minds. Every time they learned a fact, they would walk over to the section in the library that it belonged in, and open a book labeled that thing, and store the fact into that book. Fascinating! I started to picture my mind's library, and storing all the facts I learned into the correct book. So far, I didn't have too many book, or sections of the library, for that matter, in actual use. But, someday, I hoped to have a library full of facts.

"What do you want to do today" Sionna asked as we were walking out of the apartment building. Ma had found a game show to watch, and we decided to get some fresh air. The sky was blue, and it was going to be a warm one. Some kids on the corner were skateboarding and screwing around outside of the hardware store. One of them looked at us, then turned to the other two kids and they started laughing.

"What the hell?" I said, looking over at her. "What the hell is so funny about us?"

"Nothing, unless your thirteen. Thirteen year olds think everything is funny." She just smiled at me and we kept walking.

"I feel like I want to go over there and punch that kid in the face, and you're standing here brushing it off like it's nothing. Doesn't that piss you off?"

“No.” she said calmly. “Why do you let other people bother you like that? You know they’re just kids, and there’s nothing funny about what we’re doing, so, just ignore them.”

“Well I *know* that logically, but it still pisses me off” I didn’t know how to describe my symptoms of inner rage.

“Well, I’ll tell you something. Only when we become masters of ourselves, can we really deal with the world. What I mean is, the world is full of stupid, violent, seemingly useless people. But you aren’t stupid, violent, or useless. You know more than they do. You can see that your feelings are not logical, and you can deal with moving on. You have a purpose. We have to live with all kinds of people that aren’t as advanced as we are spiritually.”

“Do you really think we are more advanced spiritually? How do you know they aren’t yet, but might become like Buddha or something?”

“So if they do become like Buddha, we should definitely leave them alone, so they can follow that path. I mean, if you think one of those boys is going to become the next spiritual master, then you should be glad you got a glimpse of what they used to be like!” She just started laughing, and so did I. Thinking about one of those numbskulls becoming enlightened made me laugh.

“You’re really something, you know that?”

“You’re really something too.” She looked up at me with her ocean eyes and I leaned down and kissed her. That kiss was like slow motion. It was like there was no one else around, and if there was, it didn’t matter anyway.

“Love is the universal language, and we know how to speak it”, her face was beaming and her mouth slowly crept into a secret smile.

“You’re the only one I can speak it to, I guess.”

“That is one of our missions, I think.” She looked pensive. “We have to learn how to speak it to everyone, even strangers, and even people we don’t particularly like.”

“That’s going to be hard” I said.

“I know. That is the meaning of “loving kindness”. That is the ability to open our hearts and accept everyone, even those kids on the corner laughing at us. It might take my whole life, but I am bound and determined to find that inside of me and bring it out.”

“Let me know if you do, because if my girlfriend is loving everyone, I think I’m going to need a new one!” I started laughing.

“I could never love anyone like I love you.” That was it. That was what had not been said, and now it was said. I would remember the way she looked at me for the rest of my life. My girlfriend told me she loved me, and it was the most sincere statement I have ever heard. It really came from her heart.

“I could never love anyone the way I love you either.” We just smiled at each other and kept on walking.

Nick was laughing so hard, I thought he might fall off his couch. He had smoke sputtering out of the corner of his mouth, and his face was beet red as usual. At that moment I wondered why I had even taken the time to come over to his apartment.

“Come on, Bro. You haven’t been to my place for ages.” His argument finally persuaded me to ride over to his place and sit around with him and a couple old friends before heading to Joe’s to play pool and hassle the waitresses. This was the usual scene: Nick invites people over, Nick gets hammered, and Nick has an audience to tell his stories to. Boring. I’ve heard all this shit about a million times.

“Man,” Bob said holding the ceramic pipe and blowing smoke, “I don’t know about you guys, but I’m needin’ some new action. This girlfriend of mine used to be a freak, but she won’t put out anymore.”

“Same old story man, it never gets any better” Sammy said, taking a sip from the Bud can. “They just want to get you trapped, and then start spending your cash. Not to mention, they stop looking good after a while. It’s like they just start eating, never wear make-up, or do their hair, or any of that shit.”

“Fuck make-up man”, Bob said. “I like a natural looking girls, you know, big tits and bright eyes.” He just started sputtering smoke out.

Nick just laughed. “Hey, unless you know some Victoria Secret models around here, I’m just here to tell you there aint’ many good looking girls in Milwaukee, period. Aint’ that right Bro? Oh Wait, yea, never mind. He’s got the perfect girlfriend. She has him wrapped right now.”

“Oh wow dude, is that right?” Sammy said looking at me. “Are you being pussy whipped?” He slapped his leg and stomped one foot on the floor. “Man, do you need a ‘get out of jail free’ card or something?” The three of them kept it up a few more minutes, while I just leaned back on the rocking chair and smiled. What a bunch of morons.

“You three wouldn’t recognize class and intelligence if it jumped up and bit your ass” I said finally. “Hell, Tyra Banks could ask you for your number, and you wouldn’t recognize an opportunity. Not that I’m saying Tyra Banks is fun to be around – I don’t know her.”

“Oh Dude! You have got to be kidding me” Sammy laughed, looking more stoned by the minute. “Tyra banks can move in, take over my bank account, and have my fucking CAR if she wants!” They all started laughing again.

Apparently, tonight was not the night to get into an intelligent conversation with these three knuckle heads. It’s not like any one of them would have understood Sionna in any way. It would be like trying to explain algebra to a bug; totally useless. It did piss me off though. I mean, Nick pretends to be all understanding when we are by ourselves, but then calls me out in front of these guys. I guess he really doesn’t give two shits about how I feel. All that “I’m your best friend” crap just doesn’t hold water.

The music was turned up loud as we opened the door to Joe’s Bar and Grill. People were lounging along the wall in the room to the left, smoking and holding cue sticks. Quarters were stacked up on the sides of the pool table for upcoming games. The bar to the right was packed. People had filled the tables, and were now just standing around in between them holding onto

their beer bottles and tumbler glasses filled with mixed well drinks. A T.V. on a tall stack in the corner was inaudible with all the talking, laughing, and sounds of heavy rock music. This was the place where people like us came on Saturday nights. By people like us, I mean, the working poor and middle class. People who worked their asses off forty-plus hours a week for a measly paycheck, then spent a third of it drinking and shooting pool. I took a look around. I hadn't been in here for probably at least six months. It seemed strange to me, as if I were an alien visiting the planet, amused by the antics of the population. Everyone appeared familiar, but the lifestyle was starting to confuse me. All of a sudden it felt so – dumb. Just dumb. These people felt dumb, like they were numb from the world. They didn't want to question anything, or learn anything. They just enjoyed being miserable five days a week, happy for one, and regretful on Sunday from their hangovers and awkward sexual encounters.

Oh well, when in Rome, do as the Romans do. I had heard that, and it resonated with me right now. I took a deep breath, and stepped up to the bar beside Nick, who (of course) everyone scooched over for. Nick ordered a Jack and Coke, Sammy and Bob had BPR's, and I had a Bud. I had never been bothered by smoke before, but tonight it was making my eyes water. A couple of the waitresses sashayed by wearing blue jeans and white blouses, Joe's requirement for uniformed employees. Sammy elbowed Nick and nodded at the brunette one. Her hair was pulled back in a ponytail, and bangs ratted out puffy. She had a nice shape, but caught Sammy's look and frowned slightly with a "screw you" look. Nick just laughed.

"That Tonya, she's a feisty one." He said, taking a drink from the tumbler. "You want a date with her?" He questioned Sammy, making it sound completely possible. Anything was possible for Nick.

“Hell yeah, I do.” Sammy responded with a dull watery look in his eyes. “I would pay you back Man if you could do it.”

“Of course I can do it” Nick said. “Hold on a second; that looks like Lindsey over there.” He pointed to the other room with the pool tables. Lindsey was his ex-girlfriend, and hopeful step-daughter for my Ma. She was a pretty girl with light blonde hair and brown eyes. Nick had dumped her like a sack of potatoes because she was getting too “into his personal shit.” It had been almost a year since then, but Nick hadn’t found anyone to seriously date. I thought he had taken a vow not to get that involved again. If there’s one thing Nick can’t stand, its people questioning him. Otherwise known as “getting to know someone”. There was no right way for a girl to treat Nick. Either she was too possessive, or she didn’t take care of him enough. It was a no-win situation as far as I could tell. I felt sorry for Lindsey after the break-up, but Nick is my guy, and you just have to be on his side, no matter what.

“Yep, that looks like her” Sammy said, still glancing at the waitress who was now serving a table in the corner.

“Who’s she with? Who’s that asshole?” Nick said.

“Why does it matter Bro? You broke up with her – remember?” I just gave him that questioning look, wondering why he even cared.

“I just keep tabs on her. You know what I mean? No one told me she was seeing anyone.” He started to get that look of craziness in his face.

“Drop it man. Don’t worry about it. It didn’t work out. She can see whoever she wants.” I had to state her case because I knew that crazy look. I really didn’t want to bar fight, or explain being arrested tonight. I didn’t really want to be here in the first place.

“Kiss my ass! Did I ask your opinion?” He got up and started walking into the next room. Bob and Sammy and I just gave each other that look; that “oh shit” look. They started following, and I reluctantly did too. I wish I could just duck out the door right now, but Nick would kick my ass tomorrow if I ran.

“What’s up Lindsey” Nick asked her as he approached. She was wearing a pink sweater and boots. Actually, she looked pretty hot - more hot than I wished she did at that particular moment.

“Oh, hi Nick. Not much” she looked up at the ceiling and shrugged her shoulders. The guy she was with came up next to her and put his arm around her in a protective sort of way. He had black wavy hair and dark eyes. I would have guessed him to be Spanish, or Italian, or something. His eyes started to close slightly, in a look of suspicious anger, his caterpillar eyebrows dipped down the midline of his face. “Who is this?” the mystery man said.

“Oh, just an old friend,” Lindsey said as nonchalantly as she could. People were starting to stare. The room got quieter as the pool players paused and leaned onto their cues wondering what would happen next.

“Where did you meet this one? I didn’t hear of you dating anybody. We keep our ears out, if you know what I mean.”

“Nick, why does it matter to you?” she said, annoyed at the prospect of explaining her personal relationship with this new guy.

“Nick – leave it alone.” I tried to step in front of him, but he pushed me to the side.

“What the fuck is wrong with you?” the dark haired man said. “You got a problem with me? Hell, I never even seen you before, and you’re in my face like a little bitch!”

Uh oh, that did it. Red fire came out of Nick's eyes. His nostrils flared, and he had his fists clenched. Bob and Sammy just stood there with anticipation on their faces. They looked around at the rest of the people in the room, sizing up what could be their opponents. This had the look and feel of an all-out brawl. You could have heard a pin drop with the exception of the background music coming out of the corner speakers. An old AC-DC song blared through:

"...so join me for a drink boys....we gonna make a big noise...have a drink on me....have a drink on me..."

One of the waitresses walked backwards out of the room, and made a b-line for the back kitchen, probably to warn Joe that trouble was brewing. I had had enough of this crap. I was so tired of Nick always making a scene, causing trouble, and basically getting away with everything. Why should I stand by while he pounds the shit out of this guy he had never met before?

I stepped up closer than I had ever dared to face Nick when he was in a state of rage. I looked him in the eye, pleading with him. "Nick, Nick, listen – you don't have any problem with this guy. You don't even know this guy. Lindsey can see whoever she wants. Leave it man, just leave it."

"Keep out of it! It's none of your Goddamn business. You're going to be next if you don't get out of my face asshole." Nick kept his eyes glued on Lindsey's boyfriend. If looks could kill, the guy would have already been dead. I had seen this all before. Once he got his anger up, Nick would have his way. There seemed to be no going back at this point. I think Lindsey knew this too. She separated herself from her boyfriend and flattened against the side wall, as if to become invisible.

“Stop it! Stop it! You’re crazy as shit! No one cares about your ego Nick!” I was yelling at him, looking him in the face. I was terrified, not only of being hit, but being shunned; shunned as his brother. At that moment I knew what I was truly afraid of. I was afraid of being alone. I was afraid of having to take full responsibility for myself and trying to make my way through this life, without Nick to back me up. I was yelling at the world, I was yelling at myself.

It was like everything was in slow motion. I could see Nick’s creased brow, his mouth twisted into a weird shape, and his right fist slowly drawing back and moving toward my face. It was as if I had plenty of time to react, because time was standing still. There was no sound or movement from the other people in the pool room. My head swerved back, and I caught my backward moving motion onto my right foot. Simultaneously, Joe and his big bouncer came running into the room and they tried to restrain Nick. Then, Lindsey’s voice was all I heard “No! Stop!” Then life became a blur again. I do remember Lindsey grabbing the dark man and pushing him toward the door pleading with him to get out of there and take her home. I remember Nick turning on Joe and the bouncer and head-butting the bouncer so he could escape the hands twisted around his arms. I could hear Sammy and Bob yelling at the other guys, and trying to get Nick out of the bar.

And then all I remember was running. I was running like a bear was chasing me, jumping over obstacles in the street and darting around other people on the sidewalk. I ran, and ran, until my chest felt like it was about to explode. My ears were reverberating with the sound of my own heartbeat, and my nose stung from the cold air rushing in to fill the void each breath took from my lungs. I thought I was running home, but I found myself running to Sionna’s house, into the arms of the only person that really understood me. Into the comfort of the only person I felt I could trust. She asked me what happened, and I told her the whole story. I had to explain who

Sammy and Bob were, and how they were. She had never met any of them. She just stared at me, taking her time to think.

“Your brother tried to hit you.”

“Yes, he did.”

“No one does that, you know. I mean, no one who really cares about you.”

“He does care about me. I can’t explain Nick completely, but I’m pretty sure at this rate, you may never meet him. I don’t know if we’ll ever even talk to each other again” I said.

“Well” she said, “if he never did, you would be better off. But, I think he will. He is like a thorn in your side. He obviously has issues with his self-esteem. I think he is a controlling ass, and you are showing him that you don’t need him. You are the voice of reason, and he doesn’t understand reason.”

I just looked at her. She had a point. Nick was an ass, and he did have poor self-esteem, which I had never seen until this moment.

“I love Nick though, I mean, he’s my brother. He had always taken care of us – me and Ma. I can’t just ignore him. I’m going to have to talk to him sometime.”

“I know sweetie, but look at you. Look at all the progress you have made that he hasn’t.” Her eyes had a compassionate look, as she stroked the side of my face. “You have learned to use your brain. You have been to yoga, and meditation now for half a year. Your mind is starting to work differently. You are becoming a bravely compassionate being. You can’t let him intimidate you, or stop you from your purpose.”

“My purpose....what is my purpose?” I really had to know this. Did I have a purpose? I suppose I did, I just didn’t have a clue what it was.

“I don’t know.” She looked pensive. “I suppose everyone’s purpose is different. My thought is that we really won’t know until life is over.”

“Um, isn’t that a little too late?” I started laughing. I had been through the full range of emotions today, from scared shitless, to giddy. “I mean really, what good is it to find out the purpose of our lives when we’re dead? Assuming that we are able to think and somehow exist after we’re dead. I don’t know, I guess I’ve never thought about it much.” My amusement stopped, and now I just looked at her. There was a stillness between us as we both thought awhile.

Sionna smiled at me as she reached out to my face, cupping my jaw bones in her palms, in a motherly sort of way. “You’re exhausted. We can talk about this later. Let’s get some sleep. Why don’t you stay with me tonight?”

“I have to go check on Ma.”

“Don’t you think that is exactly where Nick will go? He is a violent, out-of-control person right now. If he finds you, he’s just as likely to kill you as he is to verbally assault you. I mean, you really don’t need that crap right now. You need rest. Your Ma is okay for one night. Please stop worrying.”

I thought for a moment. She was right. Actually, she was always right. Nick was crazy right now. I thought if I saw his face one more time tonight I would completely lose it. She sat down on the green suede sofa, and I lied down next to her. I rested my head in her lap, and she started to massage my head. It felt like such a relief. “Sionna, the first time I met you, I felt so comfortable. It was like, I don’t know how to explain it, but, it was like, I had finally come home.”

She leaned down to kiss the top of my head. I could see a watery film cover her pale blue

eyes as if she were about to cry. “Me too honey. Me too.” We lingered in that realization for a moment. “By the way – the purpose of your life is to find the true self within you, and to honor it. To be the best person you can while you’re here. That’s how I see it anyway.”

“I hope I can.” My eyes started to close, and I knew nothing else from this day. It was totally messed up, but in the end, it was epic.

The world was in black and white. I was the same man I had always been, but felt exhausted, as if I had just been in a three day battle and somehow survived. My boots were folded below my knees, stockings dirty, tunic smeared with mud and who knows what else. My head spun and my mouth was dry. I walked toward the lake, through the sand and into the reeds at the edge. I leaned down to cup the life-giving water into my hands to drink.

The wind began to howl, the water started moving, first rippling, then lapping in waves onto my leather boots. The limbs of nearby trees swayed, then bent as if a great force were upon them. From the middle of the lake she rose. It was a slow motion dance with wind and water swirling around her. I could see her face, long brown hair, and eyes of light blue. She raised her arms as if to direct nature, like a conductor directing a symphony. She appeared as an angel, with long blowing white fabric from her gown swirling around her. The long sleeves sliced through the water, and yet, she was dry.

The world suddenly had color. Vibrant greens, blues, and yellows shocked me out of semi-consciousness. She smiled, as I held my arms out to her. She was nearer to the lakeside now, and walked effortlessly through the clear, blue water. We embraced, and a feeling of total and complete serenity enveloped me. Then, without warning, alarm was there. The air was still, and we felt pure fear. Nick emerged from the woods to our right. He appeared as a giant, with large teeth and eyes of fire. He held a weapon. It was a mace he whirled above his head as he

walked towards us. The sound of the footsteps echoed and shook the earth; the chains from the mace clanged and rattled. He was out for us, and I tried to step in front of her.

She spread out her arms with her sleeves blowing out, making her appear to be flying. Nick was being pushed back with an invisible force. The two forces fought against each other – good against evil – water against fire. His face was angry and wild because his weapon would not follow the command of his body. He started to shrink to a normal size. The wind stopped blowing, and Nick disappeared into thin air. She turned and smiled at me again. I felt total relief. I started to stroke her hair and kiss her face, suddenly becoming aware of the taste of her lips. They were real lips, it was real hair....

Suddenly I bolted upright, almost slamming Sionna in the jaw with my head.

“What the?” I said, confused at the time and place I was in.

“Oh my gosh! What’s going on? We must have drifted off to sleep.” She started to rub the sleep out of her eyes. We were folded together on her couch, both disoriented. I glanced up at the kitchen clock to see that it was three a.m.

“I had the craziest dream. You were an angel, and came out of the water. You protected us from Nick with some kind of magical force!”

She started to giggle. “Well, that sounds about right.” She just smiled and closed her eyes sleepily. “Let’s go to bed and get some sleep. We’ve had an interesting day.”

“You can say that again.” We shuffled down the dark hallway, peeled off our clothes and climbed into the crisp fragrant sheets of her queen-size bed. Within minutes we were out. The next thing I knew it was nine o’clock and the start of a new day.

The next months seemed to drag on, with school, work, Ma, Sionna, and all of my homework pulling the last of my energy. I was doing well at school. It was like learning all over again how to construct paragraphs, create an argument, or just state my opinion on something I had read. I graduated from High School with average grades, never paying too much attention to anything I ever learned. I figured I would get a job and work, like all the other kids around me. I would be part of the working class, hopefully making enough money to someday buy a house and car. It took luck really. Around here, it wasn't what you knew, it was who you knew.

One guy from my graduating class became the manager of one of the Milwaukee papers. He wasn't an editor, but a human resource guy. They may have paid for him to go back to school for a degree. He started in the mailroom, and somehow wound up in charge of people. What a lucky break. All I had to look forward to was maybe becoming the manager of the pizza place. Now that I think about doing that, it cracks me up. There is so much opportunity for people that apply themselves (at least that's what I keep hearing). I had to constantly re-evaluate who I once was, and who I was now. What I mean is, that I could see myself growing. I'm not really an emotional person, but once or twice I found myself almost at the point of tears. Whether this was in response to my personal growth, or just complete exhaustion, I don't know.

Sionna was always on my mind. The first thing I thought of in the morning, all day, and then the last person I thought about at night. We saw each other every spare minute, but it just didn't seem to be enough for either of us. Because we were both always tired, we would get hyped up being around each other. We wanted to be physical, but the mental stuff kept taking up all of our time. By the time the physical stuff did happen, we would often fall asleep, blissfully

dreaming of the fulfillment we gave each other. I wanted more. Then I slammed back into reality and shuffled home to make sure that Ma was okay. Nick was completely avoiding us, and Ma was confused. She couldn't figure out why he never came around. She started to see me as the leader of our little family. Maybe Nick was just a little bit too much like dad in his abandonment. Of course, I didn't tell her why he was away. She had no idea of the bar scene, and the fact he tried to punch me out. It would have shocked her into a heart attack or something. I couldn't bear to have her thinking badly of Nick, no matter how much he had tried to hurt me. When she asked me where he had been, I would cover for him, telling her he had a poker game, or was at the gym or something. She always believed me.

Consequently, Sionna came over quite a bit. Ma was definitely happy to have her around. Sionna was so kind and took the time to make Ma feel special. She would talk to her about her day, and her meals. She would cook for her sometimes, and Ma really appreciated that. I think she really got hooked when Sionna made this outrageous casserole with butternut squash, cheese, and crunchy nuts. It was something Ma had never had (me neither), and it tasted really good. Sionna wanted to make her healthy. She was as much a help to me, as to Ma. She made sure I filled the pill containers correctly, which was good, because half the time I was so tired I could have made mistakes. She even read to Ma, when we could get her interested in anything other than the squawk-box. Ma would listen carefully, arms folded in her lap, with her little afghan around her, and then within an hour, forget everything we had read. It didn't matter though, it was truly the thought that counted. Even if she forgot what was said, she remembered who said it, and the feeling behind it, which made me feel great.

Most of the time, we would get Ma to bed, come back out to the living room, or my room, start talking, maybe have sex if we were lucky, then fall into a coma. If we were really

energetic, we would go back to her house and try staying up later, which would kill me the next day. I knew something had to give, but there was nothing to give. Everything mattered.

Everything was important, and I had to push through it. I knew in the back of my mind that someday I would be glad for the sacrifices I was making now. I also knew Sionna was watching me. She was observing how I dealt with stress, and I wanted to make her proud of me. I also knew, and this was in the farthest places in my head, that I wanted Nick to know I had done it. I wanted Nick to feel proud of me too. What a crazy thing. I would probably still be trying to prove myself to Nick, even if I turned ninety. Logically, I knew this was stupid, but I couldn't help feeling the way I did, so I just tried to accept this part of myself.

I was into my first philosophy class, which seemed to help me with managing all of these issues in my life. Sometimes though, it just lead to more confusion. I guess that's the point. The teacher, who was a middle aged guy with a beer gut, told us that it is the science of "thinking about thinking", but that it's really not a science, because it can't be measured scientifically. The entire idea was a paradox. Socrates said, "The unexamined life is not worth living." I was starting to believe this. What was the purpose of my life? It certainly wasn't working in a pizza parlor, or taking care of Ma, or falling in love, although these were important parts. Sionna and I would talk about meditating on personal and spiritual growth. If I was growing, then I was still a baby. I looked around at all the people in my world: Joe, the bar owner, Mitch at Moxie's handing out towels to people working out, or even Nick. Did these people examine their lives? I can answer that one - "no." Did that mean their lives were not worth living? I thought that was wrong too. How did this fit into spiritual growth, or un-growth? Would they return someday as different people until they figured something out? There were so many questions that I couldn't

answer, and as far as I could tell, no one in the books could answer them either. The more tired I got, the more confused I got.

I was writing a little paper on Rene Descartes, who was the founder of modern philosophy. He was the guy known to say, “I think, therefore I am.” We were talking in class about dualism, or the difference between the mind having consciousness and the brain being the center of intelligence. This set up years of debate on how the mind and the body were two different things. I was floundering along when the doorbell rang. I hadn’t expected to see Sionna for another couple of hours, but there she stood in all her beauty in my doorway. How could I separate her mind and body? They were a force to be dealt with for sure. Ma was in her chair and the two of them said “hi” to each other, then she headed back to the bedroom with me.

She flopped down on my bed with an exhausted sigh.

“Geez, what a day. I have been running around like a chicken with its head cut off.”

She went on to explain going to yoga, then the store, home to write some notes on her class in comparative religion, then to the library, and then here to see me. While she talked, all I could do was just watch her mouth move in a dreamy way, like she was taking me on a vacation from my life to visit hers for a while. Her hair was pinned up on top of her head giving her a regal quality. She wore sandals and a flowered shirt that went gently up and down as she breathed.

“I love you.” I said when she finished.

“Have you been listening to anything I said?” She smiled and squinted her eyes in a suspicious way.

“Every word”, I answered. And it was true. I hung onto every word she said. I took it all in; all the visuals and words and expressions. I took her in like it would be the last day of my life,

and I would have this memory of her when they walked me down the hallway to execution. My mind started making up this story. Of course, I recognized that my conscious mind was influencing my body at this moment, as I looked down at the excitement I had created inside my jeans. She just started laughing, and I jumped on her to kiss and roll around a little bit. I needed a break anyway.

“So, what’s your paper about?”

“Oh, it’s not really a big paper. It’s just some thoughts on dualism and Descartes.” My mind came back to reality with a bump.

“Perception is so cool to think about,” she said. “Like, is this bed here when you don’t see it? That is something philosophers spend time thinking about.”

“Does a tree that falls in the forest make a sound if no one hears it?” I said with a snort.

“Right, that kind of shit.”

“How do people come up with this stuff anyway? I mean, who cares if the tree makes a sound? Will it influence the rest of my life?” I stared up at the crack near the ceiling light.

“Well, I guess it could if it spills over to other things. Do I exist if you don’t see me? If I don’t exist when you aren’t seeing me, does it matter what I do?”

“Don’t fuck with my head. I can’t take it anymore,” I said with a sigh.

She just cradled my head in her hands and said, “You know my parents were hippies, right?”

“No, you never told me that.”

“Well, I was born in 1970, and my mom always said she got pregnant with me at Woodstock.”

“Is that right? I had no idea you were a product of the 1960’s hippie culture. What was it like as a kid?”

“Well, you know my Dad went by the name ‘Mushroom’, and my Mom went by ‘Jasmine’, I mean, how do you think I got the name Sionna?” She sat up and looked at me quizzically.

“Wow, I guess I never asked you that, although I did wonder. I have never heard that name before.”

“Sionna is a Celtic Goddess, really it’s pronounced like ‘Shanna”, but no one would get that, so they just pronounced it the way it was spelled. Sionna was the Matron of the river Shannon. She was said to be the possessor of wisdom, because the river was one of the seven rivers of knowledge springing from the Celtic underworld of the dead. Fascinating, huh?”

“Wow, that’s cool, your mom and dad put some thought into that one.”

“Well, my mom and dad smoked a lot of pot and dropped a lot of acid. I’m surprised my brain works at all.”

“You don’t have any brothers or sisters either. Why didn’t they have any more?”

She looked thoughtful. “I think they were too interested in their extracurricular activities to worry about diapers and bottles.” She looked thoughtfully at the ceiling, “actually, it was kind of nice having parents like that. It was hard keeping friends though. Once my friend’s parents met my parents – it was pretty much over.” She smiled, and I kissed her forehead gently.

“Well,” I said, “everyone knew Ma, because she worked for the school system. Which made it really hard to be a fuck-up. Although, Nick seemed to get away with everything under the sun.”

“How do you think he did that?” Her head cocked to the side, and eyes narrowed.

“I don’t know, I really don’t. That guy is a master of deception. He’s always been able to intimidate people, even the teachers. He just has that feeling to him, you know?”

“No, he sounds interesting though. I need to meet your brother someday.”

“Trust me. Take all the time in the world. It’s really not going to do anything for you, except make you feel inferior. Well, maybe not you. Actually, I’m sure not you.” I played with the ends of her hair. “Where are they? I mean, your parents. Where did they go?”

“Where all old hippies go – to the farm.” She laughed, “They are in Door County on about ten acres with a dilapidated old farm house, a little barn, a few chickens, a cow, the usual farm stuff.”

“Hey, that sounds cool. Wish I could see that.” I wondered about living out in the open, without a bunch of people around.

“Mom’s family had some money. If it wasn’t for her inheritance from Grandma, they would be nowhere. They grow their own food, can it for winter, and drink unpasteurized milk – the works. I have to admit, real eggs off the farm taste much better. Hell, I grew up drinking unpasteurized milk, and I seem to be just fine.”

“You are more than fine. You are perfect.”

She started to giggle, “You’re ridiculous, you know.”

“I might be ridiculous, but you are perfect to me. So, have you ever done drugs?”

“That’s a loaded question. I probably smoked more secondhand pot smoke before I was three than most adults do on purpose. Why do you ask?”

I continued to stare at the ceiling. “Well, I was always under Nick’s watch. It was okay for him to do anything, but catching me doing anything, and watch out! I guess I would have liked to experiment more, but I felt so much like I had to be on the lookout for Ma, I didn’t.”

“Did you want to?” She gave me that signature Sionna look; the tilted head and lifted arched brows.

“Why? Can you get some pot? We could hang out at your house and get really stoned and see what happens.”

She laughed, “I know lots of people at school that can hook me up. It’s not a big deal really. The way I see it, it will probably be legalized in a few years anyway. I mean, the government doesn’t really give a crap about health, they just want to tax things, so it’s coming.”

“You think so?” I was a little surprised. “I never even thought of that. They could just tax it like cigarettes though.”

“Exactly. Okay hun, I will do your dirty work, and get in touch with you later. I have study group in a half hour.”

My heart sank. I hated saying goodbye to her. Back to the old grind. “Yeah, I have to work at five anyhow.” We said our goodbyes, she walked out and said a few words to Ma, and I got back to the drudgery of real life.

The night went so slowly, there were hardly any orders phoned in. It was nice outside, and I just stared out at the sidewalk and the park across the street. My mind floated from Sionna to Descartes, to Nick, to the prospect of a little vacation via marijuana, and then back to the pizza oven again. I started to get very sleepy, so on break I headed two doors down to a small restaurant where a couple people were inside eating pie and drinking coffee. I ordered a large black coffee to go. I needed the jolt to get through the next hour at work and then take care of Ma and finish my paper.

When I walked out, I turned to the left to head back to the pizza place, and when I looked up, there was Kevin McCleary right in front of me. He was one of the regulars down at Moxie's. "Hey man, what's up?" He smiled in an excited way. "Haven't seen you much down at the gym. What's goin' on?" Kevin was a regular weight lifter who adhered to a very strict diet and prided himself on his body. His arms looked like the hulk, and he had his short hair gelled, and parted crisply on the side. At the gym, he was the guy to ask about protein supplements and vitamins. He did his research well, which was apparent from his small waist and muscled quads that pulled tightly on his pant legs. Even though he was much healthier, he usually went ga-ga over anything that Nick did. He would complement him on his technique, and spot him with heavy bar bench presses. He was an ass-kisser to the farthest extent possible.

"Hi Kev, umm, just haven't had the time I guess. I've been taking some classes at school and working still." I tried to look enthused with the conversation.

"Man, I heard what happened at Joe's. What the hell?" His face contorted, and eyes got big. "I heard you stopped Nick from beating some guy's ass! Man! That's tough shit! They said

you hauled off and clocked Nick. They said you had some pretty big balls! I couldn't believe it. I'm in awe, I mean, standin' up to Nick? That is the shit. People at the gym were all talkin' about it. We haven't seen Nick in a while either, so I figured it was true. Is it?"

"Look, I don't know who told you that, but it totally isn't the truth. Actually, Nick almost kicked my ass, so don't think I'm a hero or anything. I mean, I just tried to stop him. That's all." This concerned me. If Nick heard this version of the story, he really would kick my ass. Nick doesn't like to be bad-mouthed. "Please – tell everybody it wasn't like that. I'm sure Nick is just busy or something. He'll be back there, I'm sure of it. Don't treat him any different. He's just that same old Nick, know what I mean?"

"Sure, sure, man. I got ya' covered. But I'm just sayin', it's all over town. You are the hottest topic flyin' around. People are saying that Nick's little brother is a badass!" He just smiled at me and gave a weird chuckle.

"Don't believe everything you hear." I slapped him on the back and headed back to the pizza place. That was unreal. What is going on around here? First of all, I had to think, why do people give a shit? How do stories get so confused? It was like the old telephone game where kids sat in a circle. The first person said something, and by the time it got around to the end, it was completely different. People are annoyingly stupid. It also made the pit of my stomach ache. Most of the time, I would be glad to be the hero of any story, just not one that involved Nick. I felt like a fugitive, like I had to hide out until this whole ridiculous thing just went away.

Later that night I called Sionna and told her what happened. She just asked me how I felt about it, and I told her the truth. She said that was not productive. I should have a better outlook, she said. I should be capable of being the hero of the story for once, even if it isn't true. I should look at it as an opportunity for Nick to eat some humble pie, if he even hears that story, which

she thinks he probably won't. I got ready for bed, and, as I brushed my teeth and looked at myself in the mirror, I heard her voice in my head. I had to face the truth – I wasn't the same shadow of the boy I once was. I had to grow some balls. Why did I shy away from the spotlight? Why should Nick have all the glory his whole life, and me have none? Life was so mixed up, and I was exhausted. I came to the conclusion as I fell asleep that it's over. There is nothing to be done differently now. I will have to deal with the consequences from Nick someday. I hoped that someday would never come.

After class the next day, I got to talk to Sionna quickly at lunchtime. We were planning our big afternoon with the weed she had acquired. I was excited, and nervous in a certain sort of way. It had been a long time since I had smoked a little pot back in high school, but I do remember talking and laughing for a long time, then trying to sit through a Rocky movie. I can't remember which one it was, but it might have been the one where he fought the big Russian blond guy. I saw her sitting on the front porch of her house as I walked up. The sun was out, but there was a hint of rain to come. The grass was getting green, and the bulldog fenced in next door was doing his bark-grunt routine as I veered away from him. The house was an old duplex. She rented the right side as you faced the front. It was an old neighborhood, and as I looked at the houses up and down the block, they all shifted into a rather grey tone, punctuated by blue or green shutters, American flags here and there, and gravel driveways bursting with the new weeds of springtime. Rusted out cars lined the street, and a few kids rode down the sidewalks on skateboards. She smiled at me, and I hugged her a little too long before we went inside.

We sat on the old, lumpy, chocolate colored couch. She said, "Well, I got a little bit for us to smoke. The guy I know at campus was willing to sell me half the amount he likes to, but I've known him for four years, so he accommodated me."

“What do we smoke it in?” I looked around searching for some smoking implement.

“I have an old ceramic bowl. Hold on, let me see if I can find it.” She started rummaging around the living room, going through doors and shelves, until she came to a little red, oriental box. She opened the lid and retrieved a small, four inch long blue ceramic pipe with black swirly designs on it.

“Where did you get that?” I was a little surprised she would have anything so ‘permanent’, instead of just making a pipe out of aluminum foil or something.

“Oh my gosh! I’ve had this for probably ten or twelve years. I really don’t sit around and smoke pot – I’ve been a little busy.” She just laughed and we giggled together.

“No, I’m sure that your workload doesn’t jive with sitting around wasting time.” I responded.

“Well, that’s what we are doing today, just sitting around wasting time!” She started to laugh again. “I am glad I get to do this, because I love just being with you, and I think we might have some time to talk about fun stuff for once.”

“Yea, maybe we will. Who knows, maybe we’ll just get horny, or sleepy or something.” My mind started wandering around at the possibilities. She opened the plastic baggie and pinched a little of the pot into the bowl of the pipe. “I’ll go first,” she said, smiling her Sionna smile. She lit the bowl and the green leaves shriveled and popped as she sucked in the smoke. She tried to hold it for a few seconds, then started coughing as the smoke came out in little puffs, then a huge exhale. “Wow! That is pretty strong. I don’t think I’ll need much of that. Here, you go.” She held the little pipe out, and I took it. She lit it as I inhaled. The fragrant dark smell of it felt nostalgic in some way. It was like I was transported back in time. I felt like a kid again. The

smoke hit my lungs like a blast off a flame-thrower. I tried to keep it in, but the smoke rushed out in a lurch. I just laughed and coughed some more.

“Yowsa! You’re right. I don’t need much of that either.” We just sat back and rested a couple of minutes, then she walked over to put in a CD by Green Day. We sat back and listened to a song, “...

“Another turning point; A fork stuck in the road. Time grabs you by the wrist; Directs you where to go”

“What do you think this song means?” I asked her. I wondered what she would come up with. She always speculated on the meanings of things; songs, dreams, movies, and the like.

“I think it just means that none of us knows what will happen in life, but we have to make the best of things. In the end, I guess we’ll see that everything is alright.” She just twirled her brown hair around her finger, moving the bristly ends over her cheek.

“That sounds about right, guess I never thought about it before.” I sat there staring at the opposite side of the room. “I think I’m stoned. Ha ha ha ha.” I started laughing and smirking.

We talked about lots of things, which I find hard to recall now. I do remember talking about dreams and interpretations of dreams, Freud, psychology in general, and then something grabbed me as funny. She told me she could sometimes see “people’s auras.” I asked her what that meant. She said, “Well, you will probably agree that we are made of energy, right?”

“Right.”

“And energy has been proven to never end, right?”

“Right.”

“Well, energy fields surround our bodies. We kind of emanate the energy. Different people emit different colors around them, and sometimes, when I’m really lucky, I can see the colors.”

“That’s so cool! What color am I? Do you see my color right now?” I was intrigued and wanted to know about my energy.

“No, I can’t see it right now. But I can say that once or twice I saw it, and you are a beautiful color of blue, like light blue.” She smiled. To me, the color blue is peaceful and soothing. It is calm and friendly. It’s loyalty I suppose. You’re a loyal person.”

“You think so?” My eyebrows went up in disbelief.

“All you have to do is realize that you have been loyal to your Ma and your brother your entire life. That should be enough to prove it to you.”

“I guess you’re right. What color do you think you are?”

“I can’t see my own, but I feel like I’m usually blue – or purplish.”

“What does purple mean?” I asked.

“I think it denotes faith, or mystical qualities of some sort. I don’t know, I hate to sound all pompous, but, I think I might have mystical qualities of some sort.”

“You have mystified me! Let’s go outside, it’s too nice to sit here on the couch.” She grabbed her cotton fiber purse and slung it over her left shoulder.

“Ice cream! We must have ice cream!” she wailed.

“Totally.” I was having a huge attack of the munchies. We hit the sidewalk, and headed north to the Dairyland on the corner. There were only about three people hanging around the tables in front. Suddenly, I felt conspicuous, as if the house held protection, but out here in the world, it was just us. Two stoned people trying to communicate to an unlike species. It kind of

freaked me out. Somehow I managed to order a soft serve chocolate in a waffle cone and found myself sitting with her on one of the curved cement benches around a sticky white table. We were so into eating our ice cream and saying “mmm” that I had no idea someone was watching us. I looked up, and there in front of me stood Bob, Nick’s buddy.

“Wow, man! How are you?” Bob stood there with his hands in his pockets, flannel shirt untucked, and draped loosely over the small beer belly on his front side. “Haven’t seen you since the big brawl at Joe’s.”

“Oh, hey man. Umm, yeah, it’s good to see you too. I guess not – guess not.” I found myself feeling really out of place. I realized two different parts of my life had just collided. My life with Sionna, and my life with people that were my supposed “friends.” “Hey, Bob, this is my girlfriend Sionna. Sionna, this is Bob.” I did the formal introduction. Sionna stood up and shook Bob’s hand.

“Nice to meet you.”

Bob responded with a “nice to meet you too.” “Did you know your boyfriend is famous?” He started chuckling and reached into his front shirt pocket for a Marlboro and lighter.

“No, I had no idea.” She said, smiling and looking at me with a tilted head. Her eyes were a little red from the pot. I could tell she was trying not to laugh.

“Your boyfriend here single-handedly conquered the BEAST man!” He laughed out loud and light the cigarette.

“Knock it off Bob.” I just nodded my head and looked at the ground. “What the hell are you talking about man?” I really didn’t want a replay of that stupid incident, especially in front of Sionna.

“Man, you were right in Nick’s face. You moved like Bruce Lee, dog! I never seen him that pissed off in his life! You stopped that shit, man. You stopped it dead. Everybody is talking about it.”

“Oh no, don’t tell me that. I didn’t do anything anyone else wouldn’t have done. I just, I just didn’t want Nick to beat some poor guy’s ass over nothing.”

“Oh dude, you’re a hero. Everybody is bad-mouthing Nick. Sayin’ he’s a pussy, “scuse my language.” He nodded toward Sionna. “ Sayin” he’s not the same Nick as he used to be. All that shit.”

I breathed out a heavy sigh. “Please stop those stupid rumors, man. Nick is still Nick. I’m just me. Enough said.”

“Nuff said is right! Okay, okay, I get ya. Don’t want to cause any trouble. Man, you might get pissed and kick my ass!” Bob slapped his thigh in an exaggerated motion. He laughed some more. “Tell Nick I want to go hang sometime.”

“I haven’t seen Nick.” I said. “You mean, you haven’t seen him either?” I started to worry what Nick was up to.

“No, man. I haven’t seen or heard from him since that night. I thought he would be at your Ma’s or something. You know, begging to the new king of the shit hill! Ha ha ha ha ha” Now he was being plain ridiculous. “Just kidding with ya bro, just kiddin. Um, well, if you see him around, tell him Bob wants to hang out okay?”

“Yea, sure Bob, sure. I will.” Bob said something to Sionna and walked down the street flicking his ashes out at the traffic.

“Wow,” she said. “You have some pretty interesting friends.” She started laughing. I had to laugh too.

“He’s NOT my friend. He’s Nick’s friend, I just got stuck hanging out with him, that’s all.” We went on eating and chatting, but there was something now nagging at the bottom of my brain. Where was Nick? He hadn’t talked to his friends, or been at the gym. I decided it was time to end this feud and find him. We ended up sleeping at her house, and actually had a great time. Great times go too fast.

Tough times went slowly. Ma was not usually a handful, but with all the other stuff on my plate, she was becoming one. I had to constantly check to see she took her pills because she would forget. Nick was never around, it's like he disappeared off the face of the earth. This was becoming plain, old, bullshit. I had to find Nick, and even if it meant apologizing for stopping him from (in my opinion) making a complete ass out of himself, then so be it. I felt like Ma needed help – help I couldn't give her anymore. She barely remembered what she ate for breakfast, who the next-door neighbor was, even though she had known Mrs. Copekny for fifteen years or so. It went on and on with brain dead living. I love my Ma, but she was beginning to drive me nuts. Half the time she slept in the chair, half the time in the bed. Sometimes she remembered to put pajamas on, sometimes not. It was like taking care of an oversized toddler, just more opinionated.

This morning she was in the chair when I got up. “I smell something burning, can you smell it?”

“Huh?” I wiped the sleep out of my eyes. Sure enough, the kitchen smelled like burning metal. The old coffeepot had boiled dry and the metal was starting to smell. I turned the burner off, grabbed the handle delicately with an oven mitt, and threw it into the sink to cool off. “Ma, how many times do I have to tell you NOT to try to cook anything? You're going to burn the damn building down!”

“I did what?” she started sniveling. When I walked back into the living room, she had started to cry. It was like she would have sudden realizations of the magnitude of her senility, and the possible damage she could do from her brain dysfunction. I held her hands in mine.

“Now, now, Ma...come on, don’t cry. It’s not that big of a deal, really.” I tried to comfort her the best I could. In the moment I really felt sorry for her. She stared up at me with tearful eyes,

“I can’t remember anything anymore. I’m no good for anything.” Her shoulders rounded down, and the sobbing continued.

“Ma, really, stop.” Honestly, I didn’t have time for mental breakdowns right now. I had to get to school in an hour. “Its fine, Ma. Please stop.” I shook her hands and gave her a hug.

“You’re great Ma. I love you.” She looked up at me with her deer eyes.

“Nick doesn’t love me. He never comes to see me anymore. What’s wrong with him? Did I do something to make him mad?”

“No, of course not. I tell you what, I’ll go check on him. I’ll make sure everything is okay. Okay? Ma – you okay?”

“Yea, sure. I’m okay. Just make sure Nick is alright. It’s starting to worry me. My heart is a mess already. I feel it pounding a lot. Somedays I swear it’s going to pound right out of my chest.”

I took all this worth a grain of salt. If she wasn’t dizzy, she was having chest pains, or she felt so tired she couldn’t get out of the chair. It was all blurring together. Everything was blurring together. If I could get out of class a little early today, I would go over to Nicks. It was time this got sorted out so life could get back to normal. I stumbled back into the kitchen, cleared the counter crumbs and dirty dishes off, and made a quick bowl of cereal. It was a miracle my weight hadn’t wasted down to nothing. I survived on cereal, vending machine chips, and pizza half the time. It was a blessing to have Sionna come over and cook a decent meal for us.

I had a tough time in English class that day. I was supposed to be concentrating on modern fiction, but my mind was drifting back to last night. I could feel the soft linen sheets, and

Sionna's skin. I wanted to snuggle back into her bed and hold her in the darkness. The remembered smell of lavender and citrus triggered my brain into a soft, calm space. Modern fiction could go to hell right now. My head actually began to nod. I quickly snapped back into place with the high-pitched cackle of my teachers laugh. She was responding to a classmate's description of Humbert in "Lolita".

"Yes, John, many people think this is not a novel about a disturbed adult corrupting a child, but a novel about a disturbed child corrupting an adult! Hahahahaa! Well, that's it for today folks. On Thursday let's talk more about this, and please start reading "Slaughterhouse-Five".

I scooped up my books and glanced at the clock. It was only 3:45, so I had to check on Nick. After all, I promised Ma I would. I walked a fast pace to the bus stop and headed over to Nick's apartment. It was on the other side of town, about a twenty minute trip by bus. I started to think to myself -what an ass. I can't believe what an ass Nick is. Never before in my life had I ever thought of Nick this way. Times were changing, man. He once was the center of my world, and now he was just an annoying side-note. He was proving to be completely useless to Ma and me. Sionna was the center of my world now, and she actually deserved to be. When I think of the differences between them, man – one was hard-working and loud and independent and tough. And she was, okay - hard-working, independent, and tough. I just had to minus the "loud". It was a different independence; a different toughness. Hers was soft, and light, and considerate of other people. His was hard, and dark; scary, and inconsiderate of everyone. I mean, he used to be considerate of us, but not anymore. My mind started to make up stories of what he might be doing. First, I thought maybe I would just break down the door and find him dead on the floor. Then, I thought I might enter slowly and look around to see the place filled with guns, and

bombs, and Nick's face all painted with camouflage black, just like the wackos who plan to bust up a place and kill a bunch of innocent people. I smiled at my imagination as I stared out the window watching the city streets fly by. I looked up to see that we had just passed Miller Street, so I pulled the cord. I exited on the corner of Werner and headed into the brick building where Nick lives. It was pretty roomy, or seemed that way, because it was built back in the twenties, and had huge twelve foot ceilings. The old railings were carved into ornate patterns on their ends, and the light fixtures were beautiful original glass from back in the day.

I tapped lightly at first, "Nick, Nick?" After getting no response, I knocked a little louder. That first scenario of finding him dead entered my mind ever so briefly. "Stop being ridiculous" I whispered out loud to myself. Then I heard a faint shuffling sound, and thought he might be walking toward the door. The old door creaked open just a slit; the tarnished gold chain on the other side still attached. I could see the crazy brown hair and pox-marked face on the other side.

"What do YOU want?" Nick said accusingly.

"Will you let me in, please?" I answered with the best tone I could muster.

"What for?" he said.

"I think it's about time we talked this out. I mean, shit, Nick, Ma is worried about you." Just silence from the other side of the door. His eyes squinted. "I really don't need to talk to you man. Why don't you just go home? Haven't you done enough damage?"

"Nick...please...let me in so we don't have to talk through a crack. Okay?"

"This better be good, man." He closed the door briefly to unlock the chain, then opened it up so I could come inside. The living room looked like a damn tornado had gone through. Papers, trash, and empty food containers lined the coffee table and side table. The rug was covered in lint and clothing that had been dropped around at random. "Is everything okay?"

I asked. I stepped over a pile of magazines and made room on the sofa so I could sit down.

“What do YOU think, Moron?” he spit angrily back at me. I had nothing to say, I just stared blankly at him, not knowing what to expect. “You’ve ruined my life! I can’t go anywhere, Man. People are talkin’ shit about me. I can’t go to the gym. I know people are talkin’ at work too. They’re sayin’ all kinds of crap, like I’m a pussy, my little brother tried to kick my ass, all kinds of bullshit. All because of your big mouth! All because you tried to step in and be a hero. You piece of shit, you. I supposed you started some rumor to make yourself look good. Well it worked! My life is ruined, man. My reputation is dog shit. Thanks a lot Bro, thanks a lot.”

I tried to remain calm. The last thing I needed was Nick getting more pissed off than he already was, and pounding my ass. “Nick, man, whoa. Slow down. I didn’t do anything, man.” I used a slow, soft voice. It felt like I was trying to tame a wild dog. He just snickered, then got up and shuffled into the kitchen to grab a cold cup of coffee which he shoved into the microwave to heat for a few seconds. He walked back into the living area like a man obsessed, a man whose only aim was to have revenge on someone. I thought that someone was most likely me.

“Look, Nick. I don’t know exactly what happened that night. It’s kind of a blur, actually. I mean, I think I was just concerned you were going to hurt that guy for no reason. Anything I did just came out without thinking.....I truly am sorry if you think I did something wrong. It’s not what I intended to do. I just wanted to hang out, you know? Just hang out and enjoy the night. That’s all man, that’s all.” I finished my apology speech and waited to see what would happen next.

“Well, let me tell you something.” he held up a finger aimed at me. “You...YOU...are not the brother I knew, man. You’re not! All I know is now you’re some hot shit college kid with a hoity-toity girlfriend, and you know everything. Everything!”

I had to stand up to his accusations. “Nick, I’m not like that. I’m not. You just need to come over and see Ma and me more often. If you met Sionna, I know you would like her. Yes, she is smart. Yes, I am trying to dig my way out of my stupid job. But, that’s all, man. That’s all there is to it. I don’t know everything. I hardly know anything. That’s the thing about going to school; you find out how much there is out there that you *don’t* know.” I started to hang my head and look at my hands folded in front of me. “That’s where I am. I’m working my ass off, and finding out how stupid I am. That’s it, man.”

Nick just stared at me for a while. He sat back against the couch and contemplated what I had just said. I thought it was working. I thought he actually considered I might be telling the truth of it, which I was. The silence was deafening. I felt like a man on trial, waiting to hear if I had life without parole, or the death sentence. He looked around, had a big sigh, and then his eyes bored into my skull.

“I don’t really give a shit how hard you’re working. I don’t give two shits about your girlfriend, and I don’t give three shits about how dumb you are. But here is what I have to say. You are my little brother. I do care about you and Ma, and I will let it slide this time. But don’t you ever, EVER, interrupt me in public again. You got that?” He stood up over me. “I said, you got that?” His voice escalated to a louder and more dangerous pitch.

“Yes, Nick. I got that. I will try to rectify the situation with your friends, which I want you to know, I have been doing since I heard the truly fucked up story that’s out there. I mean, really...do they think I could actually stop you? Really? That’s so dumb, I mean, it’s just a stupid made up story.”

“It is a stupid made up story. And yes, you will stop it. And yes, you could never stop me from doing what I want in a million years.”

“So, will you see Ma? She’s dyin’ to see you, man.” I looked at him with pleading eyes.

“Yeah, I’ll come over there tomorrow. Tell her I’ve been sick or somethin’. Don’t tell her about any of this shit. She doesn’t know about any of this shit, right?” His forehead creased downward in suspicious manner.

“Of course not. You know Ma. Hell, she cried today because she forgot the burner was on in the kitchen. It took me a half hour to calm her down. She’s losing her memory big-time.”

“I know, I know. She’ll probably have to go to an old folks home one of these days. It’s the pits. I’m just tellin’ you man, that you have to make sure you’re takin’ care of her. She can’t be by herself, so you better be giving her her meds, or else she’s going to end up in the damn hospital.”

“Absolutely.” I stood and made my way to the door. “Thanks, Nick. It means a lot to me that you can forgive me. I’ll try to smooth things out. We’ll see you tomorrow then?”

“Yeah, yeah, see you tomorrow.” Nick opened the door, and I left feeling a little better. At least I would have some help with Ma. He was still pissed off, but I knew it would fade. The door shut, and on the other side, I heard him rustling around in the papers, and dishes. I hoped he was picking them up, but maybe he was just rearranging the mess to lay down. I went on home to check on Ma.

Ma was actually laughing! Laughing! I couldn't believe Sionna got her laughing like that. It made me feel sad that I hadn't heard that sound in so long. It was gentle and deep, really heartfelt.

"On Halloween, we would watch from the bushes, and my brothers would tip those outhouses over!" She laughed some more. She could clearly remember something from fifty years ago, but not anything she did today, or yesterday. I smiled and watched her face. She was so animated telling stories about her childhood. She was lucky, and had grown up on a small farm in Northern Illinois. She moved to Milwaukee after meeting dad. In my mind, I thought, 'what a mistake', but it was her life, and that is what she did.

"Sounds like you were a bunch of troublemakers," Sionna said with a sly smile.

"We were just plain hoodlums! But I didn't have a care in the world. It really was a nice place to grow up. My parents were good people, hardworking, and regular members of the church." She sat still for a minute, then looked at me. "Why don't we go to church anymore?" She asked me, like I was the parent, and she was the child.

"You always say you don't want to Ma. Do you want to? I'll take you if you want to."

"Yes, I do. That would be fine. Let's go next Sunday. It's been too long."

"Okay Ma, we'll go." Ugh. Like I had time for that too. It was bad enough working, and studying. Maybe I could just drop her off and pick her up. No, that wouldn't work with her dementia. Better yet, Nick could get off his lazy ass and take her. That made me laugh. If Nick

stepped foot into the church, I'm sure a bolt of lightning would hit the place. I could just see Father Van Hout giving his homily from the pulpit, seeing Nick, and choking. I laughed out loud.

Sionna looked at me suspiciously. "What's so funny?" she said.

"Oh nothin', just thinking about church and Nick, and the combination." I gave a snicker under my breath. She just nodded her head and went into the kitchen to cut some peach pie she brought over. She would heat each slice, and drop vanilla ice cream on it. Ma loved that stuff. Ma and I were just zoning out to the tube when there was a knock at the door. I walked over to open it, but it opened by itself. In walked Nick.

"Oh, hey, um hi, how are you doing?" I stammered. Suddenly I realized the fateful day had come – Nick and Sionna were going to meet, whether I liked it or not.

"Oh My God! It's you Nick! I thought we would never see you again. Where have you been hiding?" Ma was so excited, I thought she might fall out of her chair. She leaned forward to get her kiss on the cheek from the prodigal son.

"Oh, you know, just busy working and crap like that. How ya doin' Ma? This one been treatin' you all right?" He asked about me like I was her hired nurse's aide.

"Silly you, of course, of course. We are all just fine." Sionna walked in with two plates of pie. She set them on the table to wipe her hands on her jeans. Then she held out her hand to shake the hand of my brother; my brother who looked at her hand like it was attached to an alien being.

"I'm Sionna. You must be Nick. Nice to meet you, I've heard so much about you."

"Uh, yea, likewise," he reluctantly shook her hand.

"You're just in time for pie" she said, and started to turn. She stopped in her tracks as he responded,

“No thanks. I can’t eat that crap. Sugar makes me feel bloated and sick.”

“Alright, that’s fine. Let me know if you want anything. Don’t want to make you feel left out” she said.

“Right.” He elongated the word as if she had hit the nail on the head. Left out for sure.

Silence filled the room, with only the sound of the forks lightly scraping on plates.

“This is really good Nick...are you sure you don’t want some?” I asked.

“No, man. I’m sure.” Nick was staring Sionna up and down, as if deciding what to make of her. “So, I hear you’re a university lady,” he said. I thought I could detect a slight sneer from the corner of his mouth.

“That’s right.” Sionna just continued chewing with a polite smile.

“What are you gonna do when you get done?” It was a valid question, and I halfway believed my brother could pull off an intelligent conversation, convincing everyone he honestly cared about another person besides himself. On the other hand, I sat with nervous anticipation that World War III may break out at any moment. I waited for the answer...

“Well, that’s a tough one,” she began. “I have a major in English, and will have a minor in Philosophy, so, I am thinking college professor, if I can get my student teaching done and write a decent thesis. It will be another year of work before I can honestly call myself a graduate, however.” I wondered if Nick even knew what she was talking about. He slowly nodded his head, and with a heavy sigh said,

“Well, professor, I hope the best for ya. It’s tough out there, and, like I was tellin’ my kid brother here....sometimes all that school just doesn’t pay off. So, I hope you can break through that glass ceiling, or whatever. Because, you know, it’s even harder for a woman to teach at that level, or so I’ve heard.” My insides shriveled a little bit.

Sionna set her plate lightly on the table. “Well, Nick, I have to disagree with you there. As a matter of fact, in the last forty years, bachelor’s degrees earned by female students have risen from about 35 to 55 percent. Actually, there are more females in college today than males. We make up about sixty percent of all undergraduate students. This is very encouraging, and impressive, if you consider many of those women are schooling part-time, juggling the demands of family and work. In my line of thinking, I just don’t see how the future of education cannot be significantly changed for the better, by the presence of more female professors. You can’t keep a good woman down, so to speak.” She just smiled at him, picked up her plate again, and rose from the couch to take Ma’s plate.

“Oh my,” Ma said, looking at her with a tilted head. It looked like Ma could mistake Sionna for the second coming of Christ.

“Well, if you ask me,” Nick responded, “that might be one of the reasons this country is heading down the flippin’ tubes. The women in this country can’t stay home and take care of their kids.” He looked at Ma briefly, “no disrespect Ma, I know you had no choice.”

“You might be right in saying that children need the guidance of a mother figure. And you also may be right in saying that not only your mother, but many other women today, have no choice in the matter. Once you figure in the need for a dual income family just to make ends meet, and the fact that single parent families are climbing at a substantial rate, this is true. Women cannot afford to stay at home and “take care of kids” as you say. But I would have to disagree with you that this is purely the reason for a failing society, and I have to say that women in the area of education are adding other dimensions to the learning environment that have enriched the lives of students. Women bring different ways of thinking to the table, and I think students enjoy seeing this. Diversity helps us learn. After all, we are all humans trying to live on

this planet and make a difference.” She just walked into the kitchen before Nick could spit out another bigoted remark.

Inside I was jumping up and down, and yelling “that’s my girl!” I was so proud of her at that moment. Nick was sitting there stunned. Never before had someone out-worded him. Of course, no one Nick knew was actually capable of doing that. At the same time, I had fear. How would he behave towards her after this wordy showdown? She had verbally beat the shit out of him. I was loving this. “Well,” I said, “who would have known all that stuff?” I gave a slightly desperate laugh. “Gee Nick, I’m really glad you came to check on Ma. Aren’t you glad Ma?” I tried to divert attention away from Sionna.

“Oh, yes, yes, I’ve missed you dear” Ma said sweetly. He stopped internally steaming, and asked how she felt, when she had to revisit the doctor, and about her medications.

“Oh we have that all figured out. See, the kids have put all my pills into these little containers so I won’t get confused. Isn’t that right dear?” she looked towards me.

“Yea, right Ma.”

“Thanks to Sionna, everything is straightening out nicely.” She smiled and folded her hands in her lap. I thought Nick would scream. He couldn’t stand the fact that Sionna was smart, and organized, and nothing went wrong just because he was away. As a matter of fact, things got better when he was gone, and we all knew it. He finally stood, gave Ma another peck on the cheek and said, “Well, I guess I better get going. Someone in this room has a job they have to go to tomorrow.” His smile was thin and snake-like. “Sounds like you two have it all figured out, with help of course from *Doctor* Sionna.” His sarcasm floated around the room and permeated the air like foul gas. Right then Sionna walked back into the room.

“Oh gosh, are you leaving already? We hardly had a chance to talk at all.” She was sincere in this matter. She actually did want to get to know Nick. Me? I just wanted to get rid of Nick. More and more, his presence made me sick. It was this feeling in the pit of my stomach like there was too much bile, like I couldn’t smile with him around, like I was on the defensive all the time. Like I didn’t need him anymore.

“Um, yeah. Well, I’m sure I’ll see you around. Take care of this numbskull” he said grabbing my shoulders and jiggling me around a little bit. My eyes wandered up to see his face all red, and wild hair dancing around like blazes. Sionna smiled and said she would, her face the opposite, like a still, calm pool of water. I opened the door for him, and as he walked through the threshold, he lightly grabbed my shirt and whispered, “take care of Ma”, as he pulled his face in close to mine.

“Nick, you know I will” is all I had to say. I watched him walk down the hallway, already shoving his hand in his pocket to find a cigarette, which he probably would light in the elevator. He could care less if someone complained.

So, just like *A Tale of Two Cities*, it was the best of times, and it was the worst of times. I was keeping a low profile. The differences between Sionna and Nick were even more than I thought they would be. She never spoke about him, but he always had a snide remark about her. I didn't want to start a war, so I just kept my mouth shut. Nick came around more to check on Ma, and he even started laying out her pills and bringing her treats to eat. Actually, when I look back, I could see that his behavior was a little over the top. She began to trust Nick again; actually doting on him like she used to. Nick was in – and I was out. Just as well, I had plenty to do, believe me. If I wasn't taking orders at the pizza joint, I was going to the library to research the Peloponnesian Wars, or Greek mythology, or some stuff that was very necessary for modern life. As I read about Athena, my mind drifted to Sionna. They were both Goddesses of intelligence, and skill; peaceful warriors born fully armored and ready for a battle. Not that she looked for battles, but she was no one to reckon with.

Nick, on the other hand, was more like this God named Menoetius. He was described as “hubristic”, which means exceedingly prideful and impetuous to the very end. Was I in the middle of some sort of tragic Greek play? Maybe Nick and me were like the two Cyclops twins who kept trying to beat each other to the top of the mountain by throwing stones all over the one behind them. I always thought I loved Nick, but then when I met Sionna, it threw everything into a different light. Love wasn't competitive, or demeaning. Maybe I shouldn't have felt like that with him all along. I guess that's why they say you live and learn. Ma was really our touchstone at this point. If it weren't for her, we may not ever see each other. It's not like I even had time to

spend with Nick. Even if he begged me to come over, which he wouldn't, I couldn't get there anyway. Work, school, Sionna, Ma. That was it, I didn't have time for any more.

Sionna and I were talking about the universe one day. It was one of those days that turned out to be nice when you thought it was going to suck. You get something in your mind, like school, and then work, and check Ma, and stop at the post office, and all those little things that nag at the back of your brain until you get them done. Why did it seem that lately I had more things nagging at me than I used to? I knew why. It was because I had more to do and more responsibilities. I wasn't just sitting around and then going to work, I was actually doing something. It started off to be one of those annoying days. Then, out of the blue, a class cancelled due to teacher staffing issues, then the pizza joint was slow. I was free to just hang out for once, so I headed over to see my girlfriend. She was writing something on the computer in her living room about similarities in the creation stories of different religions. We started discussing this, and stuff started to make a little sense in a way. Like she said, the more you look into some things, the less you believe any of it can be true.

We talked about God, and the nature of time and space. The universe is so vast with so many galaxies, but not that long ago, man had a hard time grasping the idea that the earth was round, or that it revolved around the sun. Now it seems so stupid; but what if what we believed right now seems ludicrous in another hundred years? People will laugh at us for thinking one religion was right, and the others were wrong. They would laugh at the fact we spent so much of our time trying to follow strict rules that we think will save us from a place of fire and destruction. They may have an answer to what God really is. Maybe, like she says, it's just energy. The energy is in all of us, and everything. It existed before time as we know it, and will go on forever. Not that I can even wrap my head around "forever". Does energy give a flying

rat's ass if I live or die? I don't know. But down deep inside I think that if we all put our energy into something, like prayer, it has to work. Energy has power, so all together it has to increase that power. Like I said, I have no idea, but this is what I hope happens.

The most crazy thing ever is that Nick took Ma to mass. He just popped up Saturday afternoon and said he would take her to St. Patrick's for 4 o'clock. I didn't even know what to say. Nick, at church? I had to pick my jaw up off my chest. Ma was flustered. "What should I wear?" We said to just wear anything, because God sees you all the time anyway. She bought into that and shuffled off with Nick. As they took off in his Pontiac, all I could see in my mind was lightning bolts hitting the aisle as he stepped up to genuflect. If he gave confession, we wouldn't see him until next Christmas. I had to think to myself, "why"? In the past, I would have just been relieved someone else was doing something, but now, I had to question Nick's actions.

Now, you might think I am just being paranoid, but you don't know Nick like I do. You don't just go from tough guy, leader of the pack, scary mother, to pet your Mom's head and escort her to church. What is that? I look back at all the things Nick has ever been, and a calm, caring softy is just not one of them. Did I do something to Nick at the bar that changed him forever? I had to hope not. After all, we all love Nick the way he is. He is our fearless leader, our warrior, our Viking hero. He is also one mean son of a bitch. Down deep inside, he is "us", and I mean that he takes care of his friends and family in his own special way. What would we be? What would I be, without Nick?

There is no answer to that question as far as I know. I am riding in the passenger seat of Sionna's Toyota Civic hatchback. It was an old car, but functional always. Great gas mileage. The road wound up and down the soft hills of Eastern Wisconsin in a rhythmic calming way. It

looked like a postcard with the bright blue sky, a few cumulous clouds, pine trees, and maples showing their green leaves in the summer sun. It was absolutely beautiful and reminded me of the pictures I had seen of England's pasturelands. It was the first week of summer break, and I was actually taking a break for once. School was out for the week before summer session started, Ma was in the hands of Nick the chameleon, and we were on the way to visit Sionna's parents, Mushroom and Ginger.

"They actually like being called Mushroom and Ginger? You're sure?" I had a strange vision of walking up to two old hippies with smoke stringing out of their mouths, moccasins, the works.....

"Yep. Just call them Mushroom and Ginger. They have gone by that since the 60's. They wouldn't even respond to Robert and Margery."

"Oh, so they do have real names", I snickered as I caught a glimpse of a deer dashing among the forest floor to my right.

"Yes. They were raised right here in the good 'ol Midwest, christened with proper names and everything!" Sionna smiled, and I could feel a sense of happiness coming from her. She didn't get to see her parents very often and I knew she had fond memories of them, and they adored their only child.

"I can't imagine they have great relationships with their own parents?" I asked. How do you relate to your kids when they change their names and travel around watching the Grateful Dead?

"Actually, my father's parents had five other kids, so I think they just mentally divorced him. I do remember seeing them once at the farm. It was a bad scene with a lot of yelling and my grandmother crying. I just remember her hair piled up in a beehive, and a cheap looking blue

polyester dress. She looked at me through the screen door, tears streaming down her face. I think she knew her husband would never mend ways with dad. And of course, he never did. They're both dead now." I looked at her with pity as she wistfully continued staring through the front windshield, moving her steering wheel in a sleepy manor. "Mom's parents tried really hard to be in our lives when I was little, but Grandma and Grandpa just didn't get tofu." She started to chuckle. They also didn't get making yogurt, unpasteurized milk, drumming around an outside fire, you know."

She smiled and thought, "They also discouraged any belief in the tooth fairy, the Easter bunny, or Santa Claus. Elves....that was possible. Wood nymphs, the spiritual life of plants, trees, and water....all ok. I guess you could say I never got my hopes up unnecessarily"

"So, your parents are pagans."

She looked at me and decidedly said, "Yea. I guess that's as close as we're going to get."

PART 3

This is Murphy's Law, whatever you think is going to happen is not what happens. Basically, it's pure irony. Like that song by Morissette, "*It's like a fly in your Chardonnay, it's like rain on your wedding day....*" In other words, just when you think everything is going your way, man, suddenly, it isn't. It makes me want to wake up pessimistic. It's better for me to feel shitty, and have everything turn out better than expected, than to wake up all happy, and have things go to shit. And that's exactly what happened....everything went to shit. It's such a long story, I guess I'll just relive this nightmare.

I am a guy. What I mean by that is, I look like a guy, I act like a guy, and I think like a guy. I always grew up not having any motives for anything I did. It's quite obvious I had no future plans for myself until later in life, but it's more than that. I just trusted people; I took them for their word. If someone said to me that they were going to do something, then, dammit, they were going to do something. I also didn't try to analyze things that people say. Until recently, I mean. When you are just a guy living by yourself, you have no reason to distrust or analyze anyone's words. I mean, I just don't think like that. Then, when a woman enters your life, you start to see things from a different angle.